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Hindustan Times
FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

RAHUL, 2 OTHER MPs BOOKED IN U.P. OVER 'RAM TEMPLE CASE' SKIT

VARANASI: The Varanasi Police on Saturday registered a case against Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi, Independent MP Pappu Yadav and Samajwadi Party MP Awadhesh Prasad for allegedly "insulting Sanatan Dharma" and "hurting religious sentiments" through a skit on the alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple. The FIR was registered on a complaint by a group of seers.

Separately, BJP leaders, including MP Bansuri Swaraj, lodged a police complaint against the three MPs in Delhi. →P3

SC JUDGE STRESSES NEED TO DISCLOSE REASONS FOR COLLEGIUM CALLS

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: Supreme Court judge justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Saturday said collegium resolutions are not being forwarded with reasons and questioned whether this was a "step back" from the judiciary's commitment to transparency. At an event in Delhi, he said not attaching reasons was a disservice to many outstanding judges and creates "space for individuals to enter the judiciary who may later describe groups of people as 'ants' and make other remarks that are wholly unconstitutional." He was purportedly referring to a former Allahabad high court judge's controversial speech at a VHP event in 2024. →P9

Modi credits youth with driving India's all-round progress

HT Correspondent and Agencies
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MYSURU: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday credited the country's youth with driving India's rise as the world's fastest-growing major economy, its third-largest startup ecosystem and the nation's emerging strength in semiconductors, artificial intelligence, deep tech and space, saying young Indians were now "giving impetus to the development of the world".

The remarks came a day after Modi posted a video on Instagram offering to "forgive" students who had hurled expletives at him during weeks of nationwide protests led by the self-styled Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

Triggered by a leak of the NEET-UG paper that forced a retest for around two million students, the agitation became the biggest political crisis of Modi's third term, ending only after education minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned last week and the government accepted the demonstrators' demands, including examination-system reforms and the withdrawal of police cases against protesters.

Modi was speaking on Saturday after inaugurating the

continued on →7

→PREZ CLEARS ANTI-PAPER LEAK BILL, P5

PM Narendra Modi and Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar at the inauguration of the Swami Vivekananda Cultural Youth Centre in Mysuru on Saturday. ANI

YOUNGSTERS DON'T NEED HIS FORGIVENESS: RAHUL COUNTERS MODI

Senior Opposition leaders on Saturday attacked Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his Instagram video in which he said he wanted to forgive the country's youth for the abuse directed at him during the recent protests. Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said the Prime Minister should instead apologise to students for saddling them with a "corrupt" examination system, adding that they did not need his "forgiveness". →P3

TAKE INSPIRATION FROM TILAK'S INTERPRETATION OF GITA: SHAH TO YOUTH

Union home minister Amit Shah and National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval on Saturday urged the country's youth to dedicate themselves to nation-building and rise above personal gains. Addressing a gathering after presenting the Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026 to Doval at a function organised by the Tilak Smarak Trust in Pune, Shah appealed to young people to draw inspiration from Bal Gangadhar Tilak's interpretation of the Bhagavad Gita. →P3

INDIA'S CWG GOLD RUSH

A dominant display by boxers, who won seven gold medals, coupled with a para shot put title, swelled India's tally at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow

DMK MOVES SC, SEEKS IMMEDIATE CAUVERY WATER RELEASE FOR TN

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Saturday moved the Supreme Court (SC) seeking a direction to Karnataka to immediately release Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu and comply with the directions issued by the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA). The move comes even as Tamil Nadu is in the process of filing an appeal before the Supreme Court, amid concerns over a water crisis in the state during a crucial phase of the agricultural season in the Cauvery Delta. →P7

W Asia braces as Trump orders more Iran strikes

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WASHINGTON/TEHRAN: President Donald Trump has ordered the US military to carry out a new attack on Iran as soon as this weekend, the Wall Street Journal reported on Friday, prompting Tehran to accuse the country of "escalating regions" in the battle-torn region.

Hours later on Saturday, Kuwait said that it responded to a new round of drone attacks from Iran while a tanker was struck in the Strait of Hormuz.

Speaking to reporters on Friday during a meeting with members of his Cabinet at the Camp David presidential retreat in Maryland, Trump said "we just want to win" in Iran and signalled that he expected US military action to continue for some time.

He said the US will hit Iran "very hard" until they can't take it anymore.

Later, White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt expressed the US administration's frustration anew, charging that Tehran last month signed a memorandum of

continued on →7

COMMERCIAL LPG RATE CUT, ATF PRICES HIKED

The prices of commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) — used in establishments such as hotels and restaurants — were on Saturday cut by a steep ₹192 per 19-kg cylinder while aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were hiked by ₹5 per litre in line with divergent trends in benchmark rates. While a 19-kg commercial LPG cylinder in Delhi now costs ₹2,738 as against ₹2,930 previously, ATF rates have been raised to ₹115 per litre from ₹110, according to price information from state-owned oil firms. →P7

Kashmir terror attack toll rises as second migrant worker dies

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SRINAGAR/RAIPUR: A labourer from Chhattisgarh, who was injured along with another worker from the state in a terrorist attack in Jammu & Kashmir's Kulgam district, died of gunshot wounds on Saturday, officials aware of the development said. The other worker succumbed on Friday.

Deepak Ratre, 24, from Sakti district, and Bhupendra Bhaina, 28, from Sarangarh-Bilaigarh district, had migrated to J&K this year in search of work, people aware of the matter said.

The two were working at a brick kiln when the gunmen attacked them, in what was the second terror strike in the Union territory since the 2025 Pahalgam attack and the first to claim civilian lives.

Chief minister and National Conference leader Omar Abdullah condemned the "dastardly" killings as leaders across party lines denounced the attack and security forces stepped up operations to trace the attackers. →P5

A soldier frisks a man during a security check in J&K's Kulgam district on Saturday

ARMY, RAJ POLICE CRACK DOWN ON ILLEGAL SALE OF MILITARY FATIGUES

NEW DELHI: In a joint operation targeting the illegal sale of battle fatigues, the Indian Army and Rajasthan Police seized nearly 1,000 metres of unauthorised army-pattern combat cloth from multiple shops in Rajasthan's Sriganganagar town, the army said on Saturday. The seizure points to a wider network supplying counterfeit military uniforms to vendors in the region, it added.

The action followed a seizure of similar counterfeit combat cloth in Bareilly in June this year, which the army traced to a manufacturing source in Sriganganagar. →P7

MHA clears DFS plan for nearly 11k new posts

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NEW DELHI: The Union ministry of home affairs has technically vetted the Delhi Fire Service's proposal to increase its personnel strength, approving the creation of 10,743 new posts and paving the way to plug a longstanding gap in emergency response service, according to documents accessed by HT.

The move will raise the sanctioned strength of the department from 3,175 to 13,918 personnel and mark its first major manpower augmentation proposal since 2010.

THE MOVE WILL RAISE THE SANCTIONED STRENGTH OF THE FIRE DEPARTMENT FROM 3,175 TO 13,918 PERSONNEL

Chief fire officer AK Malik confirmed the development and said the department's assessment, in the proposal document, was based on Delhi's rapidly expanding urban landscape and evolving emergency response requirements.

FAMED CLIMBER NIRMAL PURJA, 9 OTHERS, KILLED IN AVALANCHE

SKARDU: Renowned mountaineer Nirmal Purja and his nine climbing companions were all killed by an avalanche in Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir (PoK) during an ascent of one of the world's highest mountains, his expedition company said on Saturday, as rescuers tackled treacherous conditions to recover their bodies.

The avalanche struck on Thursday, cutting off contact with the international expedition led by Purja, a 43-year-old British-Nepali climber, on Broad Peak. →P8

EMBATTLED NTA OPENS BIDS FOR NEW SECURITY CONTRACTOR

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NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has floated a ₹7.5-crore tender to hire a professional security agency for "round-the-clock security services" at its headquarters on Minto Road, regional offices in Okhla and other notified locations, as the examination body undergoes a major overhaul following the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak. Bids can be submitted till 3pm on August 17. →P3

{ UEFA SAYS 'LOST CONFIDENCE' }

FIFA drops WC stake sale plan, but backlash clouds Infantino's future

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NEW YORK: FIFA President Gianni Infantino abandoned a controversial plan to create a commercial entity that would have opened the door to outside investors for the World Cup, bowing to intense opposition from key regional football bodies and top clubs.

However, the move did little to quell the spiralling discontentment around Infantino, whose position appeared increasingly imperilled.

Gianni Infantino

"Having listened carefully to all the views, it has become clear that the project has created divisions of a nature that, regardless of the level of support, are no longer in the interest of the objective set out in the first place," Infantino said in a statement.

Hours later, UEFA — Europe's football governing body — welcomed the withdrawal but issued a scathing rebuke on Saturday, calling the FIFA proposal a "shabby, back room, opaque deal" that was

continued on →7

Modi backs Vizag economic region, unveils new airport

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HYDERABAD: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday announced that the Centre would extend all support to the upcoming Visakhapatnam Economic Region, which he said would play a pivotal role in Andhra Pradesh's development and evolve into one of Asia's major economic hubs.

Addressing a public meeting after inaugurating the Visakhapatnam Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport at Bhogapuram, Modi said the Centre was committed to creating the infrastructure and ecosystem needed to turn the region into a major investment and employment destination.

He said the NDA government's development strategy focused on attracting investments that would increase production, boost exports and generate employment.

"Investment leads to production, production leads to exports, exports create employment, and employment transforms people's lives. This is the development model the NDA government is pursuing," the Prime Minister said.

Calling the day a landmark in Andhra Pradesh's march towards the 'Swarna Andhra Vision', Modi said projects worth nearly ₹18,000 crore, including the new international airport, had been launched.

He said it was a matter of pride that the Bhogapuram airport was named after freedom fighter Alluri Sitarama Raju, who sacrificed his life for the rights of tribal communities. Calling the airport a "runway and launch pad" for the aspirations of North Andhra's youth, Modi said it would boost employment and regional development.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu during the inauguration of Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport at Bhogapuram in AP. PTI

Modi highlighted the expansion of India's aviation network, saying the country had 74 airports before the NDA government came to power, compared with 166 now. He said air connectivity had expanded to smaller towns and the UDAN regional connectivity scheme had enabled millions of first-time passengers to travel by air.

He also highlighted infrastructure projects in Andhra Pradesh, including the Coastal Economic Corridor, modernisation of ports from Visakhapatnam to Krishnapatnam, new ports at Moolapeta and Ramayapatnam, the Visakhapatnam-Raipur Expressway and railway connectivity projects worth ₹1 lakh crore. More than 70 railway stations in the state are also being modernised, he said.

Modi said Visakhapatnam's pool of young talent in software, information technology and emerging technologies made it an ideal destination for futuristic industries.

He said the foundation had been laid for a semiconductor manufacturing facility in the city, while investments were also coming into artificial intelligence infrastructure, data centres and other advanced technology sectors.

He said a Google data centre was among the major investments planned in the state and announced Centre's support for one of India's largest pharma parks at Nakkapalli.

Modi also said Rayalaseema was expected to attract ₹5 lakh crore in green energy investments. "During my visits to Andhra Pradesh over the past three years, he had launched development projects worth nearly ₹2 lakh crore," he said.

Addressing the event, chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu praised Modi's governance and highlighted India's digital public infrastructure, financial inclusion and infrastructure expansion.

"India's digital public infrastructure has become a global benchmark under Modi's leadership and the world's largest volume of digital transactions now takes place in India, surpassing countries like the United States and China," he said.

Naidu said the Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile (JAM) trinity and Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) system had strengthened financial inclusion. He also highlighted the expansion of highways, railways, ports and metro networks.

He said India's economy had risen from the 11th-largest to the fourth-largest in the world under Modi's leadership and described him as the "right leader at the right time".

Naidu appealed to people to support Modi's vision, saying India's long-term progress was closely linked to the realisation of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Deputy chief minister Pawan Kalyan, state IT minister Nara Lokesh and Union civil aviation minister K Rammohan Naidu attended the event.

Gateway to North Andhra

The Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport, described as the "Gateway to North Andhra", was built at a cost of nearly ₹4,727 crore in 31 months.

The airport can handle six million passengers annually in its first phase, with a master plan to expand capacity to 40 million passengers.

Developed by GMR Visakhapatnam International Airport Limited (GVIAL) under the public-private partnership model, the 2,703.26-acre project includes airside infrastructure, commercial development, residential zones and approach roads.

Its 3,800-metre Code-E runway can handle wide-body aircraft such as the Boeing 777, Boeing 787 Dreamliner, Airbus A330 and Airbus A340. The airport also has advanced airfield lighting, navigation aids and CNS/ATM infrastructure for domestic and international operations.

A 25,000-metric-tonne annual-capacity cargo terminal is expected to strengthen North Andhra's export ecosystem.

Delimitation is BJP's conspiracy, says Rahul

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Congress leader and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Saturday alleged that the BJP-led Centre's proposed delimitation exercise was aimed at reducing Tamil Nadu's political influence and urged all parties to oppose it in Parliament.

Speaking to reporters at Mamallapuram near Chennai after attending the concluding session of a 10-day training camp for District Congress Committee (DCC) presidents, Gandhi described the move as a "conspiracy" against Tamil Nadu.

"It is a very important issue for the future of the Tamil people, the Tamil language and the state of Tamil Nadu. BJP is attempting to carry out delimitation, which is designed to disenfranchise and take away power from the Tamil people. This is a BJP conspiracy," Gandhi said.

He urged all political parties in the state to oppose the proposal, alleging that it would weaken Tamil Nadu's voice in national politics.

"Anybody who supports delimitation is betraying Tamil Nadu and is allowing RSS and the BJP to attack the people of Tamil Nadu," he said.

"No Tamil person should support delimitation. Every single Tamil party, national party should defeat delimitation (bill) in Parliament," Gandhi added.

Drawing a parallel with Ettappan, the 18th-century Tamil ruler of Ettayapuram who is widely remembered in Tamil history for allegedly aiding the British against freedom fighter Veerapandiya Kattabomman, Gandhi said, "Anybody who supports delimitation is a 21st-century Ettappan." Earlier in the day, Gandhi met families of students who allegedly died by suicide over issues related to the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) and asserted that students are told to work honestly in a system that is not honest with them.

Rahul Gandhi addresses media after attending the Congress leaders training camp in Tamil Nadu on Saturday. PTI

After the interaction, he said in a post on X, "Nothing is more painful than seeing a parent grieve for their child. Behind every young life lost is a family carrying pain that will never leave them — and serious questions about a broken education system."

"Leaked papers, cancelled examinations. Years of preparation destroyed overnight. Our students are told to work honestly in a system that is not honest with them," he added.

Targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Gandhi said, "He has not met a single grieving parent. He has not sat with a single student whose future was stolen by a leaked paper. India's students do not need his forgiveness. They are owed his apology." During his visit, Gandhi also held closed-door consultations with senior Tamil Nadu Congress leaders, including former state unit presidents, MPs, ministers and legislators, on the political situation in the state.

Responding to Gandhi's remarks on delimitation, Tamil Nadu BJP spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathy accused the Congress leader of making irresponsible statements.

"Here is a person who is so irresponsible, trying to create unrest in the country, supporting anarchists and wanting to divide the nation as the Congress did during Partition," Thirupathy told HT.

"Unable to resist or live without power and money, Rahul exposes himself that he would go to any level to grab them, even if it means joining hands with evil, anti-national and external forces," he added.

Six dead as heavy rain batters Kerala, rescue operations on

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Heavy rains lashed several parts of Kerala on Saturday, triggering landslides, inundating low-lying areas, swelling rivers and dams, and prompting authorities to launch large-scale rescue and evacuation operations in affected regions.

A statement from the CMO said six people were killed in rain-related incidents across the state.Four of the deaths occurred in separate landslides in Idukki and Kottayam districts, where several others were rescued.

Search operations for the six missing persons continued with personnel from the National Disaster Response Force, Fire and Rescue Services, police, the Coast Guard, the local administration, public representatives and residents participating in the efforts, the statement said.

The statement said 65 relief camps had been opened across the state, providing shelter to 1,465 people.

Chief Minister V D Satheesan said 17 houses had been destroyed and another 127 had suffered partial damage in rain-related incidents.

Two separate fatal landslides were reported in Idukki district.The deceased was identified as Sumathi (65), a resident of Adoormala near Kudayathoor in Idukki district.

Rescue personnel during a rescue operation following a landslide due to rain triggered floods in Kottayam, Kerala on Saturday. PTI

Her husband, Ravi, and their son, Ratheesh, were rescued and admitted to hospital, officials said.

In another incident, Prabhakaran Nair (77) of Vaikom died after a landslide hit the house of his relative in the Vagamon area of Idukki district.

A youth died, and his mother was trapped under debris after a landslide at Payyanithottam in Poonjar in Kottayam district.

The deceased was identified as Josephine, son of Johny.

His mother, Rejina Johny (46), was trapped under debris, officials said.

Following the landslides and flooding, Satheesan directed ministers in charge of rain-hit districts to camp in their respective districts and coordinate rescue and relief operations as heavy rain continued across the state.He reviewed the situation with ministers and district collectors.

Landslides and flooding hit several parts of Idukki district.

At Upputhara, a parked police jeep was damaged in a landslide. Heavy rain disrupted traffic at multiple locations.

Vehicle movement on the Kochi-Dhanushkodi National Highway was affected following a landslide near Cheeyapara.

Rising water levels in the Chottupara stream at Vandiperiyar led to waterlogging on National Highway 183.

In neighbouring Kottayam district, heavy rain triggered widespread flooding in Erattupetta, Kanjirappally, Koottickal, Erumeli and Pala, inundating commercial and residential areas, disrupting traffic and prompting rescue operations.

Four houses were damaged in a landslide at Teekoy village, but residents escaped unhurt, officials said.

Panel led by Montek begins 3-month push to boost TN revenues

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu's Revenue Augmentation Committee, chaired by economist Montek Singh Ahluwalia, held its inaugural meeting virtually to discuss its terms of reference and outline its strategy and next steps, senior government officials said on Saturday.

The state government constituted the committee on July 29 to suggest measures for sustainable augmentation of tax and non-tax revenues by improving compliance, plugging leakages, rationalising rates, fees and exemptions, and identifying new and under-tapped resources, an official release said.

The move aims to strengthen Tamil Nadu's fiscal self-reliance and create fiscal space to meet its developmental commitments. The committee will be supported by a dedicated research team from the Tax Policy Research Unit and Financial Data Analytics Unit of the finance department. It will also draw on the experience of other states.

"It will frame its recommendations across short-term, medium term and long-term measures," the release said.

The committee was formed against the backdrop of a White Paper released by the government in June 2026, which laid out a roadmap for better revenue mobilisation and administrative reforms.

Montek Singh Ahluwalia

The White Paper observed a decline in revenues from Goods and Services Tax, Value Added Tax, excise, and mines and minerals due to "administrative choices", leakages and corruption in the past. It outlined long-term, multi-year reforms focused on curbing corruption, enforcing compliance and mobilising resources efficiently.

The committee members include honorary professor at the Centre for Policy Research, Delhi, Dr K P Krishnan; tax policy expert and convener of the Task Force to Rewrite the Income Tax Act (2017-18), Arbind Modi; former chairman of the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBEC), Najib Shah; Tamil Nadu finance department additional chief secretary M A Siddique; and director of the Madras Institute of Development Studies, Chennai, M Suresh Babu.

The committee has a three-month tenure.

SENTHIL BALAJI HITS OUT AT TVK GOVT OVER CASES AGAINST HIM

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Former minister and senior DMK leader V Senthil Balaji on Saturday criticised the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), accusing it of focusing on filing cases against him instead of addressing people's demands and grievances.

Balaji made the remarks after marking his attendance at Triplicane police station as required under his bail conditions.

"People would have seen that cases are filed not only against me but against various people," he told reporters.

"Courts are there, lawyers are there. No matter how many cases they (TVK government) file, legally we will face them in court and prove that all of these cases are false," he said.

The Supreme Court on July 31 granted Balaji anticipatory bail until further orders in a corruption case concerning alleged irregularities in the state-run Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (TASMAC).

Referring to an alleged attempt to poach a TVK MLA, Balaji said, "Even though my name was not mentioned in the complaint, my name was added. Because of this, I obtained anticipatory bail and have been marking my attendance every day morning and evening (at Triplicane police station)."

He said the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption had also registered an additional case and conducted raids at several places, including the room where he stayed.

Balaji said he had written to the investigating officer seeking temporary exemption from marking his attendance for a few days, citing consultations with senior advocates.

"The same letter was also filed yesterday requesting a 5-day exemption. Based on the appropriate orders by the Supreme Court, the investigation is proceeding properly today, and I am extending my cooperation at the police station as required," he said. On the arrest of two people on Friday, Balaji said, "From what I enquired, out of the two people, one was named in the complaint in that First Information Report while the other was not named." "Even though he was not named, he has been arrested. Therefore, everyone whose name has been registered is now legally prepared to face the case," he said.

Two persons identified as Balaji's associates were arrested by vigilance sleuths in connection with alleged irregularities in the TASMAC case, police said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, CM DK Shivakumar during the inauguration of the Swami Vivekananda Cultural Youth Centre at the Sri Ramakrishna Ashrama in Mysuru on Saturday. PTI

CM Shivakumar urges PM Modi to extend support, save K'taka

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MYSURU: Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Saturday appealed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi to extend support to Karnataka, saying the country's growth was closely linked with the state's progress and urging greater cooperation under the spirit of cooperative federalism.

Addressing the gathering after the inauguration of the Swami Vivekananda Cultural Youth Centre - Viveka Smaraka - in the presence of the Prime Minister here, Shivakumar said Karnataka and Bengaluru had become India's window to the world and sought the Centre's support for the state's development. "Today, my Prime Minister is here, and on behalf of the Government of Karnataka and all the people of this state, I request him to be generous in helping Karnataka and saving Karnataka, because the entire world is looking at India through Karnataka and Bengaluru," he said.

Calling the inauguration "a historic event for the youth movement of this country", the chief minister recalled Swami Vivekananda's words: "Be broad-hearted when you are defeated; be large-hearted when you are victorious".

Referring to former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee's visit to Bengaluru for laying the foundation stone of the international airport, Shivakumar said Vajpayee had remarked that world leaders had begun visiting Karnataka and Bengaluru before travelling to Delhi.

"That is the strength of our great people," he said as he recalled that S M Krishna, a former chief minister and an alumnus of the Ramakrishna institution, was heading the state at the time.

SHIVAKUMAR SAID KARNATAKA AND BENGALURU HAD BECOME INDIA'S WINDOW TO THE WORLD AND SOUGHT THE CENTRE'S SUPPORT FOR THE STATE'S DEVELOPMENT

Appealing for closer Centre-state cooperation, Shivakumar said, "Prime Minister Sir, you can see the weather, you can see the culture. This is the strength of this great state. The entire state stands with you. We want to work together. We want to strengthen the spirit of cooperative federalism. I appeal to you -- let us all work together".

The chief minister also recalled Swami Vivekananda's vision of making India a centre of science and said that inspired industrialist Jamsetji Tata to seek land from the Maharaja of Mysuru for establishing the Indian Institute of Science in Bengaluru.

"The Maharaja granted more than 300 acres of land in Bengaluru. That land became the Indian Institute of Science. This was the Maharaja's great contribution to the scientific advancement of the nation, and the Tata family supported that vision," he said.

Emphasising Karnataka's role in national development, Shivakumar said, "India must grow with Karnataka, and Karnataka will always stand with India. Let us work together and make this country proud".

DMK moves SC over Cauvery water crisis

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CHENNAI: The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Saturday moved the Supreme Court (SC) seeking a direction to Karnataka to immediately release Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu and comply with the binding directions issued by the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA). The move comes even as the Tamil Nadu government is in the process of filing an appeal before the Supreme Court.

The DMK moved the apex court seeking urgent directions to the Karnataka government to comply with the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) July 28 direction to release 3,500 cusecs of water per day at Biligundlu for 15 days commencing July 29. Karnataka had challenged the order before the CWMA, but its appeal was dismissed on July 30.

Meanwhile, the Tamil Nadu government will approach the Supreme Court on Monday over the sharing of Cauvery water with Karnataka, minister for natural resources and law R Nirmal Kumar said on Saturday.

Kumar said consultations with legal experts had been completed and the state would file a case in the apex court on August 3. "The Karnataka chief minister (DK Shivakumar) have been speaking against Tamil Nadu over the release of water. Therefore at this junction on Monday, day after tomorrow, following the orders of the chief minister (C Joseph Vijay), a case will be filed in the Supreme Court," he told reporters in Madurai.

Kumar claimed Karnataka had released only 3,500 cusecs, or about 4.5 TMC, of water, against the 17 TMC it should have released over the past two months.

"Combining all of these things, a case will be filed on August 3," he said.

Three Instagram account holders booked over posts targeting Rahul

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BENGALURU: The Bengaluru Cyber Crime Police have registered an FIR against three Instagram accounts for allegedly sharing defamatory, abusive and objectionable content targeting Lok Sabha Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi. The case was registered following a complaint by a member of the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) legal cell, with police launching an investigation to identify the account holders.

According to the complaint, the Cyber Crime Police registered the FIR on Thursday night after receiving allegations that Rahul Gandhi was targeted through defamatory and offensive posts on social media.

The complainant alleged that the content was intended to tarnish the reputation and public image of the senior Congress leader.

THE COMPLAINANT ALLEGED THAT THE CONTENT WAS INTENDED TO TARNISH THE REPUTATION AND PUBLIC IMAGE OF THE SENIOR CONGRESS LEADER

The FIR names the Instagram account "ground.reality_india", which allegedly uploaded a 30-second video on July 16 with the caption, "Why is the Opposition party silent?" The complaint states that the video contained derogatory, abusive and sexually offensive remarks directed at Rahul Gandhi. It further alleged that the post was deliberately designed to provoke viewers and damage the dignity of the Leader of the Opposition.

Besides the primary account, two other Instagram users, "raashtravaadhi2" and "manvithamanojsamanvi", have also been named in the FIR.

They are accused of posting provocative and defamatory comments below the video, which, according to the complainant, further amplified the offensive content.

"We have registered three separate cases for allegedly posting derogatory remarks against Rahul Gandhi," cyber police inspector G Suresh told HT on Saturday.

"We have begun collecting digital evidence, including the video, comments and account details. We are working to trace the identities of the individuals operating the Instagram accounts and determine whether additional persons were involved in creating or promoting the allegedly objectionable material," he added. Officials said further legal action would be taken based on the outcome of the probe.

Oppn hits back at Modi over his 'forgive students' message

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NEW DELHI: The Congress and the Samajwadi Party on Saturday hit out at Prime Minister Narendra Modi after he said in a late-night Instagram video that he had "forgiven" the country's youth for the abuse hurled at him during protests, with Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi asking the PM to apologise to the country's students for giving them a "corrupt" exam system and that they didn't need his "forgiveness".

In an Instagram video released late on Friday, the PM said that he could understand the anguish prevailing in society, but stressed that this was the time to guide the youngsters. "I want to forgive them. People make mistakes, but this is a cultural shock that our daughters are using such abusive language. The statement came amid the controversy over some of the protesters allegedly using abusive language against Modi. "Not only was I subjected to abusive language at Jantar Mantar, but even my late mother was abused there," he said.

Slamming the video in a post on X, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi said: "Nothing is more painful than seeing a parent grieve their child... Behind every young life lost is a family carrying pain that will never leave them - and serious questions about a broken education system."

The remarks came shortly after Gandhi met the families of those who lost their children during his day-long visit to Tamil Nadu.

"Leaked papers. Cancelled exams. Years of preparation destroyed overnight. Our students are told to work honestly in a system that is not honest with them... And the Prime Minister has the audacity to speak of 'forgiving' students," the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha added.

Gandhi said he (Modi) has not met a single grieving parent. "He has not sat with a single student whose future was stolen by a leaked paper. "India's students do not need his forgiveness. They all owed his apology," he said.

Senior Congress leader and former Union minister P Chidambaram asked: "Has the Honourable Prime Minister also forgiven the BJP trolls who react on X with abusive and filthy comments to posts critical of the government?"

Congress leader Pawan Khera said, "The country was demanding an apology, but the PM ended up forgiving the country instead."

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav said, "The public will never forgive the BJP. Even if the BJP offers a prostrated apology (dandavat maafi), the public will still not forgive them. The BJP did not keep the promise it made to the public. The BJP's arrogance alone will bring down their government."

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Uddhav Thackeray, too, said: "Modi and (Union home minister Amit) Shah should apologise to students and their families because of the way students were bashed up with sticks fitted with nails, pellet guns and tear gassed... some male police tore clothes of women protesters."

The government has pushed back against the charge that it is avoiding accountability, pointing instead to the passage of the Public Examinations Amendment Bill and the formation of a task force on examination reforms.

The central government has maintained that it was "completely ready for a healthy, facts-based debate in Parliament," and noted that Akhilesh Yadav and several Congress MPs had themselves said the issue should be discussed in the House, adding that it was "due to the ego of one individual".

BJP leader Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi said, "On one hand, there is Prime Minister Narendra Modi's sensitivity, and on the other, the arrogance of these feudal champions is clearly visible. Their conduct reflects frustration and despair."

Girl apologises for remarks against PM

A girl who purportedly appeared in a viral clip abusing Prime Minister Narendra Modi issued an apology video on social media on Saturday, saying she had been "influenced" and that this was her "first and last mistake".

The girl, who said she is 15, said the viral video was not posted by her and she was "extremely embarrassed and ashamed." HT could not independently verify the authenticity of the apology video. The apology video came after a Zero FIR was lodged against her in Noida.

Bill to raise punishment for paper leaks gets Prez assent

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NEW DELHI: President Droupadi Murmu has given her assent to the legislation aiming at raising the punishment for unfair means in public examinations, days after the bill was pushed through both the Houses of Parliament by voice vote earlier this week.

In a gazette notification issued on Friday, the law ministry said President Murmu has given her assent to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026.

According to the legislation, individuals involved in paper leaks or unfair means in exams will get jail terms for a minimum of five years and a maximum up to 10 years and a fine up to ₹50 lakh.

Earlier, the punishment scale was three years jail term, extendable up to five years and ₹10 lakh.

For organised crimes, the amended law proposes a minimum sentence of seven years and a fine of up to ₹10 crore. The law outlines 15 illegal acts, including leaking question papers, tampering with OMR sheets, creating fake websites and issuing fake admit cards.

The government pushed for an early passage of the Bill by Parliament amid massive protests across the country by students against the NEET 2026 paper leak. President Murmu's assent came within days of Parliament clearing the bill, bringing the amended penalties into force from the date of publication.

Dedicate yourself to nation building, Shah, Doval tell youngsters

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PUNE: Union home minister Amit Shah and National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval on Saturday called upon the country's youth to dedicate themselves to nation-building and rise above personal gains.

Addressing a gathering after presenting the Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026 to Doval at a function organised by the Tilak Smarak Trust in Pune, Shah said, "I appeal to all young people to read the Gita through Tilak Maharaj's perspective. I can guarantee that if you do, you will not make mistakes in life."

Doval called upon young people to commit themselves to national service, saying that India was still on its journey towards becoming a fully developed nation. "Today's youth should dedicate themselves completely to the national interest. They should be willing to sacrifice personal interests whenever required and remain focused on strengthening the nation," he said.

The NSA also said that India was fortunate to have the leadership of Modi and Shah, adding that both possessed the vision and commitment to make India a strong and developed nation.

The remarks came amid the political fallout from the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP)-led student protests, during which some demonstrators allegedly raised abusive slogans against Modi. In an Instagram video released on Friday night, the prime minister said he had forgiven the protesting students who allegedly abused him and urged young Indians not to let anger consume them.

Chief minister Devendra Fadnavis, deputy chief ministers Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Pawar, and other dignitaries also attended Saturday's function, where Doval was conferred the award in recognition of his contribution to national security.

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval receives the 'Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026'. PTI

Praising Doval's contribution to India's security architecture, Shah said he was the country's longest-serving national security adviser. Recalling his association with Doval, the Union home minister said, "I came to know him after the Gujarat serial bomb blasts when I was the home minister of Gujarat and Narendra Modi was the chief minister. On Modi's advice, I met Doval. His inputs not only helped us crack the Gujarat blast case but also several other similar cases across the country."

Shah added that the Multi Agency Centre (MAC) has emerged as the backbone of India's internal security under the Modi government and credited Doval with laying its foundation. Doval said that India continues to face challenges from both internal and external forces. "Not everyone is happy with India's growing strength and development. There are countries and forces, both within India and abroad, that believe India's rise would be detrimental to their interests. Citizens must always give the highest priority to what is in the nation's interest," he said.

FIR against Rahul, 2 MPs over Parl skit

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VARANASI: The Varanasi Police on Saturday registered a case against leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and two other MPs for allegedly "insulting Sanatan Dharma" and "hurting religious sentiments" during an opposition protest inside the Parliament complex on Friday, when the lawmakers enacted a "skit" on the "chanda chori" (offerings theft) at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, a senior police officer said. Separately, BJP leaders, including MP Bansuri Swaraj, filed a police complaint against the three in Delhi.

Deputy commissioner of police (Kashi Zone) Gaurav Banswal said a delegation of seers, led by Mahant Balak Das -- the head of Patalpuri Math in Varanasi -- filed an application at the Kotwali police station, demanding that a case be registered against the three MPs -- Gandhi, Pappu Yadav and Awadhesh Prasad -- who participated in the "skit".

Rahul Gandhi is the Congress MP from Rae Bareli. Pappu Yadav is an Independent MP from Purnia constituency in Bihar while Awadhesh Prasad is the Samajwadi Party MP from Faizabad seat in Uttar Pradesh.

Rajesh Ranjan (Pappu Yadav) and Awadhesh Prasad

The case was registered under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) sections 196 (promoting enmity between different groups on grounds of religion, race, place of birth, residence, language, etc, and doing acts prejudicial to maintenance of harmony), 299 (deliberate and malicious acts, intended to outrage religious feelings of any class by insulting its religion or religious beliefs), 302 (uttering words, etc., with deliberate intent to wound religious feelings of any person) and 3(5) (common intention, when multiple people do a criminal act together with a shared plan).

Balak Das said the manner in which Pappu Yadav insulted Lord Ram and Sanatan Dharma was unforgivable.

"No follower of Sanatan Dharma can forget this act. It has hurt our religious sentiments. So we have demanded that a case be registered," he added.

In New Delhi, MP Swaraj, accompanied by BJP MLAs, submitted a complaint at the Parliament Street police station, alleging that the opposition leaders mocked the Sanatan culture in the garb of the protest.

"Yesterday, on the Parliament premises, under the guise of a protest, MPs Pappu Yadav ji, Awadhesh Prasad ji and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi ji staged a drama. This was not a protest. It was a mockery of Sanatan culture, a ridicule of the saint community, and a scornful insult to Indian traditions.

Anybody who backs delimitation is betraying Tamil Nadu, says Rahul

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CHENNAI: Congress leader and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Saturday alleged that the BJP-led Centre's proposed delimitation exercise was aimed at reducing Tamil Nadu's political influence and urged all parties to oppose it in Parliament.

Speaking to reporters at Mamallapuram near Chennai after attending the concluding session of a 10-day training camp for District Congress Committee presidents, he described the move as a "conspiracy" against Tamil Nadu. "It is a very important issue for the future of the Tamil people, the Tamil language and the state of Tamil Nadu. BJP is attempting to carry out delimitation, which is designed to disenfranchise and take away power from the Tamil people. This is a BJP conspiracy," Gandhi said.

He urged all parties in the state to oppose the proposal, alleging it would weaken Tamil Nadu's voice in national politics.

"Anybody who supports delimitation is betraying Tamil Nadu and is allowing RSS and the BJP to attack the people of Tamil Nadu," he said.

"No Tamil person should support delimitation. Every single Tamil party, national party should defeat delimitation (bill) in Parliament," Gandhi added.

Drawing a parallel with Ettappan, the 18th-century Tamil ruler of Ettayapuram who is widely remembered in Tamil history for allegedly aiding the British against freedom fighter Veerapandiya Kattabomman, Gandhi said, "Anybody who supports delimitation is a 21st-century Ettappan."

Earlier in the day, Gandhi met families of students who allegedly died by suicide over issues related to NEET and asserted that students are told to work honestly in a system that is not honest with them.

After the interaction, he said on X, "Nothing is more painful than seeing a parent grieve for their child. Behind every young life lost is a family carrying pain that will never leave them — and serious questions about a broken education system."

Targeting PM Narendra Modi, he said, "He has not met a single grieving parent. He has not sat with a single student whose future was stolen by a leaked paper. India's students do not need his forgiveness. They are owed his apology."

Responding to Gandhi's remarks on delimitation, state BJP spokesperson Narayanan Thiruputhy accused him of making irresponsible statements.

"Here is a person who is so irresponsible, trying to create unrest in the country, supporting anarchists and wanting to divide the nation as the Congress did during Partition," he said.

TOOK ME 19 YEARS TO SAY I HAVE RETURNED TO KOLKATA: NASRIN

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KOLKATA: Just like history remembers who closed the door on you, it also remembers who opened the door for you, exiled Bangladesh-born author Taslima Nasrin said while delivering an address at a cultural and felicitation program in Kolkata.

Nasrin returned to Kolkata after more than 18 years, after she was forced to leave Kolkata in November 2007 by the then Left Front government.

"It took me around 19 years to say that I have returned to Kolkata. In an exiled person's calendar, each passing year is not just a measure of time. Every year is like a closed door, every month is a wait and every day bears the pain of losing her address. After returning to Kolkata, I feel like coming back to a part of life which I left behind here," she said.

Three organisations, Paschimbonger Jonno, Human Rights Beyond Frontiers and Secular Mission, organised a cultural event where Nasrin — who lives in Delhi since 2011 on a long-term resident permit granted by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government — was felicitated.

The Bangladesh government forced the 63-year-old author to leave the country in 1994 after she received death threats from several Muslim organisations over her writings and the book Lajja (shame).

She moved to Europe and lived in several countries. Nasrin has been living in exile in India since 2004. West Bengal chief minister Suvendu Adhikari, who attended the program said, "You are welcome. You have experienced the change in West Bengal. You can come to West Bengal not just once, but as many times you want."

Modi inaugurates new int'l airport near Vizag

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HYDERABAD: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday announced that the Centre would extend all its support to the upcoming Visakhapatnam Economic Region, which would play a pivotal role in Andhra Pradesh's development journey and evolve into one of Asia's most significant economic hubs.

Addressing a public meeting after inaugurating the Visakhapatnam Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport at Bhogapuram, Modi said the Centre was committed to creating the necessary infrastructure and ecosystem to transform the region into a major investment and employment destination.

Modi said NDA government's development strategy was centred on attracting investments that would generate employment, increase production, boost exports, and ultimately improve the quality of life for people.

"Investment leads to production, production leads to exports, exports create employment, and employment transforms people's lives. This is the development model the NDA government is pursuing," he said.

PM Narendra Modi ANI

Describing the day as a landmark in Andhra Pradesh's march towards achieving the 'Swarna Andhra Vision', he said projects worth nearly ₹18,000 crore, including the inauguration of the new international airport, had been launched.

The Prime Minister said it was a matter of pride that the Bhogapuram airport had been named after freedom fighter Alluri Sitarama Raju, who sacrificed his life for the rights of tribal communities.

More transparency need of the hour in collegium's operations: SC judge

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NEW DELHI: Justice Ujjal Bhuyan of the Supreme Court on Saturday observed that collegium resolutions are not being forwarded with reasons, questioning whether this was a "step back" from the principle of transparency that the judiciary has always embraced.

Releasing a report on the Judicial Transparency Index at an event in the Capital, justice Bhuyan said that not giving reasons is a disservice to many genuinely outstanding judges. Conversely, he said: "By withholding reasons, we also create space for individuals to enter the judiciary who may later describe groups of people as 'ants' and make other remarks that are wholly unconstitutional and contrary to the values of the Constitution." He was apparently referring to a controversial speech made by a former Allahabad high court judge at a VHP event in 2024 in a veiled reference to Muslims.

> By withholding reasons, we also create space for individuals to enter the judiciary who may later describe groups of people as 'ants'
> **JUSTICE UJJAL BHUYAN**

Justice Bhuyan said, "A judiciary that has embraced publicity in its adjudicative function has been markedly more cautious about extending the same principle to its own constitutive processes."

He cited three recent Supreme Court collegium statements that do not contain any reason for recommending elevations as opposed to the earlier trend when detailed reasons accompanied resolutions forwarded by the collegium. "Is this a step back from the principle of transparency," he asked.

He further observed that deliberations in the collegium remain confidential and reasons for rejecting or deferring a recommendation are rarely disclosed in full and the criteria applied are not codified in any publicly accessible instrument comparable to the Memorandum of Procedure.

Batting for open courts, he said, "There is no doubt that open courts make it possible for the public to develop reasonable perceptions about the judiciary, by enabling them to directly observe judicial behaviour, the processes and outcome of cases."

On the recent SC hearing where use of judicial proceedings on social media was sought to be regulated, justice Bhuyan said the move by the CJI-led bench does not retreat from live-streaming. "Court's concern is precisely that decontextualised fragments of oral exchanges, observations made by judges in the course of argument, not findings, are being circulated with sensational captions, causing reputational harm to judges, advocates, and litigants..."

Next Dy Chief of Naval Staff assumes charge

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NEW DELHI: Vice Admiral AN Pramod, who played a key role in planning Operation Sindoor and led the Indian Navy's response during the West Asia crisis, on Saturday assumed charge as the Deputy Chief of Naval Staff, the navy said.

He served as the Director General Naval Operations (DGNO) between December 2023 and July 2026. "As DGNO, he was closely involved in the planning, preparedness, and operational readiness of the Indian Navy during Operation Sindoor and conduct of maritime security operations during the ongoing West Asia crisis," the navy said on Saturday. Pramod succeeded Vice Admiral Tarun Sobti, who completed his tenure and retired on July 31.

An alumnus of the 38th Integrated Cadet Course, Naval Academy, Goa, Pramod was commissioned into the Indian Navy in July 1990. A Communication and Electronic Warfare Specialist, he is an alumnus of the Defence Services Staff College, Wellington, and the Naval Higher Command Course at the Naval War College, Goa. In a distinguished career spanning over 36 years, he has held a wide range of command, operational, instructional, and staff appointments, both afloat and ashore, the navy said.

Vice Admiral AN Pramod

Meanwhile, IAF deputy chief Air Marshal AK Bharti, who was DG (Air Operations) last year and closely associated with planning Operation Sindoor, retired on Friday. Bharti was succeeded by Air Marshal Tejpal Singh on Saturday. Commissioned in June 1990 as a fighter pilot, the Air Marshal has over 3,500 hours of flying experience.

ED ATTACHES ₹63L ASSETS IN UKSSSC PAPER LEAK CASE

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DEHRADUN: The Enforcement Directorate has attached movable and immovable properties worth ₹63.30 lakh in connection with the UKSSSC graduate-level examination paper leak case under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

According to ED, the attachment pertains to assets allegedly acquired by accused Hakam Singh Rawat using proceeds generated from the 2021 UKSSSC paper leak. The agency said its investigation found that Rawat received around ₹95 lakh from candidates and attempted to project the proceeds as legitimate income through bank deposits, agricultural income claims and income tax filings.

Leak-weary NTA seeks new security contractors

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NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has floated a ₹7.5 crore tender to hire a professional security agency for round-the-clock security services at its headquarters on Delhi's Minto Road, regional offices in Okhla and other notified locations, as the examination body undergoes a major overhaul following the NEET-UG 2026 controversy.

According to the request for proposal (RFP) document, seen by HT, the selected agency will provide "comprehensive security services" to safeguard NTA personnel, visitors, assets, premises, confidential examination material, server rooms, strong rooms, warehouses, record rooms and other critical infrastructure housing sensitive examination records. The contract will initially be for two years and can be extended by two additional one-year terms based on performance. The tender was issued on July 25 and bids can be submitted until 3 pm on August 17. Technical bids will be opened the same day.

The RFP requires bidders to have at least five years of experience in professional security services, an average annual turnover of at least ₹10 crore over the past three financial years and prior experience in securing central government organisations, examination agencies, universities, airports, hospitals, metro systems or other high-security establishments.

According to the document, the estimated value of the contract is ₹7.5 crore, excluding GST, though NTA has reserved the right to increase or reduce deployment requirements and split the work if necessary.

> THE AGENCY HAS BEGUN PROCESS TO SEEK BIDS FOR A 2-YEAR CONTRACT TO PROVIDE 24-HR SECURITY TO ITS HEADQUARTERS AND OFFICES AT OTHER LOCATIONS

Bidders will also have to furnish an earnest money deposit of ₹15 lakh and a performance security equivalent to 5% of the contract value. Unlike conventional government procurement based solely on the lowest financial bid, NTA has opted for a Quality-and-Cost Based Selection (QCBS) model, saying that "the sensitive nature of NTA's examination ecosystem and confidentiality requirements" makes quality of service paramount.

Under the evaluation process, technical quality will carry a weightage of 70% and financial bids 30%. Only agencies securing at least 70 out of 100 marks in the technical evaluation will qualify for the financial round, the document says.

The technical assessment will evaluate bidders on their experience in high-security environments, workforce strength, financial capacity, ISO certifications and a presentation on deployment strategy. Agencies will also be assessed on their proposed use of technology, including GPS patrols, biometric attendance systems and incident-reporting mechanisms.

The selected agency will be responsible for regulating entry and exit, ensuring that "only authorized persons enter restricted areas", preventing unauthorised access, maintaining visitor records and deploying handheld and door-frame metal detectors at entrances and confidential locations. Security personnel will also be tasked with protecting examination material, IT infrastructure, server rooms and storage facilities.

The document does not specify what security arrangements existed earlier or whether the facilities were guarded by an outsourced agency or in-house personnel. Queries sent by HT to the NTA and the Union education ministry remained unanswered till the time of print.

The move comes days after the CBI filed a charge sheet against all 13 arrested accused in the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case.

INSTAGRAM USERS BOOKED FOR POST AGAINST RAHUL

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BENGALURU: The Bengaluru Cyber Crime Police have registered an FIR against three Instagram account holders for allegedly sharing defamatory, abusive and objectionable content targeting Congress MP Rahul Gandhi.

The case was registered following a complaint by a member of the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) Legal Cell. The FIR, registered on Thursday, names the Instagram account "ground.reality_india" for alleged defamatory video, and Instagram users "raashtravaadhi2" and "manvithamanojsamanvi" for posting provocative and defamatory comments below the video.

HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

Get up, get going, get active and take our quiz

It's been a full week for the world, but a fuller one for sports. We're covering football, ballet, weightlifting, prodigies and prizes in these questions. Plus the news you thought you forgot

Rachel Lopez

Mirabai Chanu won gold at the Commonwealth Games. Which state is she from? PTI

Anahat Singh is junior World Champ in which sport? HT

1 India has no official definition for Billionaire. But 576 Indians reported an income of ₹X on their IT returns for '25-'26. For '23-'24, only 284 Indians declared ₹X. For '24-'25 there were 415 people earning ₹X annually. Give the magic number.

2 An actor. The son of an actor. And now a pro-footballer. This man joins Mumbay FC's Durand Cup Squad and could travel for a group-stage match in Shillong. Prepare for War on the field, and a Baaghi with some Heropanti. Who's kicking off?

3 It's a clear flammable liquid. It's the active ingredient in alcoholic drinks. It's also in industrial solvents and renewable motor fuel. It's made when yeast ferments sugars and starches from corn, sugarcane or grain. Rev up and name it.

4 Yoko Morishita started at age 3, and at 77, is the oldest of her kind who is still taking on lead roles. She's played Clara in the Nutcracker for 45 years under Japan's Matsuyama company. Her shoes are satin. Her jetés grand. What is her job?

5 Weightlifter Mirabai Chanu defended her crown, winning her third straight Commonwealth Games gold. She's 31 and did a total lift of 190kg. Name her beautiful, troubled home state. It's surrounded by Assam, Mizoram, Nagaland and Myanmar.

6 It induces euphoria, a burst of energy, a fast heart rate and high blood pressure. 13 tonnes of it, disguised as bananas, were seized from a Spanish port in 2024. The investigation now reveals a network linked to Wall Street. But what is it?

7 Anglo American is looking to divest its 85% stake in this 138-year-old carbon-selling brand. Botswana owns the other 15%. The company (and sparkly industry) is in a slump for its bloody trade history and lab-grown competition. The brand's name?

8 Congrats, Anahat Singh. She's India's first junior World Champion in this 196-year-old game. It is played in a four-walled court, where opponents share the same playing space, use a small, low-bounce rubber ball. A verb, a veggie, a sport. What?

9 Elon Musk wants to remake a movie. His, he claims, will be a historically accurate version of a 2,800-year-old poem. And he'll use his AI tool Grok Imagine for it. The war is over. The way is long. The warrior is lost. The Muses sing. Which poem?

10 Spanish midfielders Fabian Ruiz and Gavi got traditional presents for the World Cup win: Crates of a vegetable (technically, a fruit) equal to their body weight. They went home with 150kg in all. Good for gazpacho, paella and salsa. What veggie?

Answers on page 07

Delhi judges shuffled; Ajay Gupta to tackle paper leaks

Shruti Kakkar
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NEW DELHI: Two days before the inauguration of the special courts at the Rouse Avenue Court Complex, to hear cases under the National Investigation Agency (NIA) Act and other special laws, the Delhi High Court on Saturday ordered a major reshuffle in the Delhi Higher Judicial Service (DHJS), transferring and assigning new postings to 138 judicial officers, including 13 judges designated to the special courts.

As part of the reshuffle, judge Ajay Gupta has been assigned to preside over the designated special fast-track court for the trial of criminal cases involving question paper leaks and the use of unfair means in public examinations. The reassignment follows the transfer of judicial officer Anu Grover Baliga, who was appointed as special judge (Prevention of Corruption Act) (CBI)-25 last Thursday and has now been posted to one of the exclusive special courts constituted to try cases under the NIA Act.

The decision on the transfers was taken in a full court meeting. The transfers will be in effect from August 4, a day after the inauguration by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant along with Delhi High Court chief justice, DK Upadhyaya, and the Portfolio Committee of the Rouse Avenue Court complex, headed by justice Jyoti Singh.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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Kulgam terror attack toll rises to 2

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SRINAGAR/RAIPUR: A labourer from Chhattisgarh, who was injured along with another worker from the state in a terrorist attack in Jammu & Kashmir's Kulgam district, succumbed to his gunshot wounds on Saturday, officials aware of the development said. The other worker succumbed on Friday.

Terrorists had attacked two brick kiln workers late on Friday in the Kelam area of the south Kashmir district, where one of them — identified as Deepak Ratre (24) — died on the spot, while Bhupendra Bhaina (28) succumbed to his injuries later.

A senior doctor at SKIMS said that Bhaina had received bullets in his chest and all efforts by doctors failed to revive him. Ratre, a resident of Sakti district in Chhattisgarh, and Bhaina, who belonged to Sarangarh-Bilaigarh district of the state, had migrated to J&K this year in search of work, people aware of the matter said.

The attack follows closely on the heels of another incident less than 10 days ago, in which terrorists allegedly shot and killed a police officer deployed on Amarnath Yatra security duty.

Chief minister and National Conference leader Omar Abdullah condemned the "dastardly" killings and announced an ex gratia relief of ₹10 lakh each for the families of the labourers. The amount is in addition to the immediate assistance of ₹6 lakh each announced by the district administration. "They had come to Kashmir to work. People from outside the state had come here to earn an honest livelihood. Those innocent people were targeted in such a manner. The attack cannot be condemned enough," he said.

Bhupendra Bhaina and Deepak Ratre

J&K lieutenant governor Manoj Sinha on Saturday chaired a high-level security review meeting in Srinagar, where he directed all the deputy commissioners and SSPs to conduct a comprehensive review of the Standard Operating Procedures (SoPs) established to protect labourers from outside J&K.

The meeting also discussed the security arrangements in place for the ongoing Amarnath Yatra and strengthening of the security grid.

During the day, security forces conducted several operations across south Kashmir to trace the killers of two labourers.

The Chhattisgarh government, too, announced an ex gratia of ₹20 lakh each for the families of the workers. "The Chhattisgarh government stands firmly with the bereaved families...," chief minister Vishnu Deo Sai said.

Meanwhile, a political controversy erupted on Saturday after National Conference president and former chief minister Farooq Abdullah questioned the timing of the Kulgam terror attack. "It is not even known who carried out the attack or who the perpetrators are. There must be an investigation to identify the attackers. I do not know why this happens only when we ask for the restoration of statehood," Abdullah said.

The remarks drew sharp criticism from BJP leader Ravinder Raina, who said: "When innocent labourers are brutally murdered by terrorists, the nation expects every political leader to stand united against terrorism, not to make speculative statements, create confusion or divert attention from perpetrators," he told ANI.

HUSBAND, HIS SISTER HELD IN DEHRADUN DOWRY DEATH CASE

DEHRADUN: An Uttarakhand state secretariat official and his sister were arrested on Saturday in connection with the alleged dowry death of his wife, a government school teacher, four days after she was found dead under suspicious circumstances at her matrimonial home in Dehradun district's Harrawala village, police said.

"On the basis of evidence, police arrested state secretariat official Saurabh Khatri, 36, and his sister, Surbhi Khatri alias Charu, 37, on Saturday," said SSP Pramendra Dobhal.

Police said the two were arrested from their residence in Laxman Enclave of Harrawala in Doiwala block.

"During the investigation, police recorded the statements of the complainant and other witnesses. We also obtained a video that the deceased had sent to her mother before her death, in which she stated that she had been facing continuous harassment by her in-laws since her marriage," Dobhal said.

"Our investigation into the matter is underway. Strict action will be taken against all culprits," he said, adding that police would request the court to ensure a speedy trial.

The woman was found hanging on July 29. An FIR was registered same day against her husband, mother-in-law and sister-in-law under Section 80(2) of BNS, based on a complaint by the victim's mother. **HTC**

Charges framed against ex-cops in Antilia bomb scare

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MUMBAI: A special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court on Saturday framed charges against ten accused in the Antilia explosives scare case, including former police officers Sachin Waze and Pradeep Sharma, paving the way for the trial to begin.

Among the others against whom charges were framed are former assistant police inspector Rayazuddin Kazi, Waze's colleague at the Crime Intelligence Unit (CIU); former Crime Branch police inspector Sunil Mane, and ex-constable Vinayak Shinde.

The case relates to the discovery of an abandoned green Mahindra Scorpio near billionaire industrialist Mukesh Ambani's residence, Antilia, on Carmichael Road in South Mumbai. The SUV, discovered at the location on February 25, 2021, contained 20 loose gelatin sticks and a threatening note.

The case is linked to the murder of Thane-based trader Mansukh Hiran, owner of the Scorpio. Hiran's body was found in the Thane creek on March 5.

At the centre of the case is dismissed former assistant police inspector Sachin Waze, who headed the CIU of the Mumbai crime branch at the time. He was dismissed from service and is currently in judicial custody.

Sachin Waze

The five private individuals facing charges are cricket bookie Naresh Gor, who allegedly provided SIM cards to Waze and Sharma's alleged henchmen; Santosh Shelar, Anand Jadhav, Satish Mothukari and Mani Soni.

Seven of the ten accused were present before special NIA judge Chakor S Bawiskar on Saturday. All of them, including the others through their lawyers, pleaded "not guilty". They have been charged with criminal conspiracy, abduction, murder under relevant sections of the Indian Penal Code and terrorist acts and conspiracy to commit a terrorist act under relevant sections of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1969, as well charge under the Explosive Substances Act.

The court has posted the matter for August 3, for pre-trial formalities to be completed before it starts recording evidence.

{ HYDERABAD LAND PLEDGE CASE }

Sebi bars ZEEL for two months; Chandra, Goenka for one year

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NEW DELHI: Sebi has prohibited Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd (ZEEL) from the securities market for two months and its chairman emeritus Subhash Chandra and MD & CEO Punit Goenka for one year over unauthorised pledge of the company's Hyderabad land to secure loans availed by promoter-linked Essel Group entities.

Additionally, the regulator imposed a total penalty of ₹1.48 crore on them, according to a 150-page final order passed late on Friday. Individually, the regulator imposed penalties of ₹30 lakh on ZEEL, ₹60 lakh on Chandra, and ₹58 lakh on Goenka.

The case relates to the execution of a Deposit and Declaration Agreement on December 27, 2018, under which original title deeds of ZEEL's Hyderabad property were handed over to Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd as security for loans taken by Essel Home and other borrowing entities linked to Essel Group.

Sebi noted that the deployment of ZEEL's property constituted a related-party transaction and the company failed to obtain prior approval from its audit committee, thereby violating Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements regulations.

The regulator further observed that ZEEL failed to make necessary disclosures in its financial statements despite Goenka and Chandra having knowledge that the Hyderabad land had been deployed as security and the title deeds remained with the lender until June 2020.

In its findings against Chandra, Sebi said he misused his position as chairman by handing over the original title deeds of ZEEL's Hyderabad property to IHFL after falsely representing that the action had the approval of ZEEL's management.

"Noticee No.3 being the chairman of ZEEL, misused his position and authority in ZEEL and handed over the original title deeds of the asset (Hyderabad Land) of ZEEL to IHFL by falsely declaring that the said action had the approval of the management of ZEEL. Through such actions, the noticee put the material asset of ZEEL at risk for his personal benefit," Sebi said in its order.

Sebi directed ZEEL, Chandra, and Goenka to pay the penalties within 45 days. The order came into force with immediate effect.

CENTRE RELEASES ADDITIONAL TAX DEVOLUTION OF ₹1.09 L-CRORE

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NEW DELHI: The Union finance ministry on Saturday said the Centre has released additional instalment of tax devolution to state governments amounting to ₹1.09 lakh crore, which is in addition to the normal monthly amount.

Currently, 41% of taxes collected by the Centre is devolved in 14 instalments among states during a fiscal year.

"The Union government has released additional instalment of tax devolution to state governments amounting to Rs 1,09,019 crore on 1st August 2026, which is in addition to the normal monthly devolution to be released on 10th August 2026," the ministry said in a statement.

"This release is in line with the commitment of Government of India to strengthen the finances of States to accelerate their capital and developmental expenditure," it said.

As per the ministry's statewise distribution of net proceeds of Union taxes and duties for August 2026, Uttar Pradesh received the highest allocation at ₹17,908 crore.

Tax devolution is the constitutionally mandated transfer of a share of the Centre's divisible tax pool to states.

GST collections cross ₹2.11 lakh-crore in July

Rajeev Jayaswal
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NEW DELHI: India's gross Goods and Services Tax collections in July crossed ₹2 lakh crore for the second time in the current fiscal year with 15.4% year-on-year jump to surpass ₹2.11 lakh crore, which is the third highest monthly collection since the GST regime was unveiled on July 1, 2017.

The GST regime entered its 10th year with a monthly gross GST collection of ₹2,11,205 crore as against ₹1,83,065 crore in July 2025, reflecting India's economic resilience, steady domestic consumption and effective compliances, according to finance ministry data released on Saturday.

Collections from domestic transactions rose 10.1% in July to ₹1,44,695 crore from ₹1,31,439 crore a year earlier, while revenues from imports jumped 28.8% to ₹66,511 crore from ₹51,626 crore.

Net GST collection in July 2026, after refunds, also saw a robust double-digit growth, which stood at ₹1,81,237 crore in July 2026, registering 15.8% jump from ₹1,56,570 crore in July 2025. Total refunds rose 13.1% to ₹29,968 crore from ₹26,495 crore in July last year.

To be sure, the July collections relate to business transactions undertaken in June.

COLLECTIONS FROM DOMESTIC TRANSACTIONS ROSE 10.1% IN JULY TO ₹1.44 L-CR FROM ₹1,31,439 CRORE A YEAR EARLIER

Deloitte India partner MS Mani said: "The high GST collections which reflect business transactions during June 26 ties up very well with the 7.3% increase in industrial production during June. It reflects continued economic resilience despite the challenges in the external environment."

Experts, however, pointed at high growth in monthly GST collections on imports, which could be either because of imports of inputs for domestic value-addition or for purely consumption. EY India tax partner Saurabh Agarwal said, "One cannot ignore the elevated levels of import GST collections, which remain a nagging concern. This points to a persistent gap in domestic manufacturing capability despite the range of successful PLI [production linked incentive] and Atmanirbhar Bharat interventions rolled out over the past few years."

Commercial LPG prices down ₹192, jet fuel rates hiked by ₹5 per litre

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NEW DELHI: The prices of commercial LPG — used in establishments such as hotels and restaurants — were on Saturday cut by a steep ₹192 per 19-kg cylinder while aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were hiked by ₹5 per litre in line with divergent trends in benchmark rates.

While a 19-kg commercial LPG cylinder in Delhi now costs ₹2,738 as against ₹2,930 previously, ATF rates have been raised to ₹115 per litre from ₹110, according to price information from state-owned oil firms.

COMMERCIAL LPG CYLINDER OF 19 KG IN DELHI NOW COSTS ₹2,738 AND ATF IS PRICED AT ₹115 PER LITRE

This is the second straight monthly reduction in commercial LPG rates following a ₹183.5 cut on July 1. In case of ATF, the revision reverses the reduction by a similar proportion that was effected on July 1.

The two reductions in commercial LPG rates on July 1 and August 1 followed the West Asia crisis pushing rates to record highs in June. After the outbreak of the conflict in late February, commercial LPG rates had risen by a massive ₹1,373 per 19-kg cylinder — from ₹1,740.50 in February to ₹3,113.50 in June.

Alongside, prices of 5-kg market priced LPG cylinder were cut to ₹762 from ₹808.50.

These prices — revised on the first of every month, based on benchmark international prices and foreign exchange rates — vary from state to state depending on local taxes such as VAT.

Domestic LPG rates in household kitchens remain unchanged at ₹942 per 14.2-kg cylinder.

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CBI REGISTERS FIR AGAINST RELIANCE CAPITAL LTD IN EPFO LOSS CASE

HT Correspondent
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MUMBAI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a First Information Report (FIR) against Reliance Capital Ltd (RCL), its directors, key managerial personnel and others for allegedly causing a wrongful loss of ₹1,816.22 crore to the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO).

The FIR follows a complaint filed on July 21 by an EPFO representative alleging that RCL issued secured Non-Convertible Debentures (NCDs) in 2013 and 2014, in which the pension body invested ₹2,500 crore through four portfolio managers for a 10-year period.

According to the complaint, the EPFO received periodic coupon payments from RCL under the NCD terms until September 2019, when the company's credit rating was downgraded to D, leading to a default on its repayment obligations.

RCL was at the time a Reliance ADA Group. In 2021, the company entered the insolvency resolution process and was in March 2025 acquired by IndusInd International Holdings Limited (IHIL).

The EPFO lodged a claim of ₹3,306.67 crore — comprising a principal amount of ₹2,500 crore and accrued interest of ₹808.67 crore — after the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) in Mumbai admitted RCL to the corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP).

Following the approval of the resolution plan by the NCLT that resulted in the IHIL takeover on March 19, 2025, the EPFO recovered ₹1,492.45 crore, leaving an unrecovered principal of ₹1,007.55 crore and admitted interest of ₹808.67 crore.

IHIL and RCL could not be reached for comment till the time of going to print.

The EPFO decided to lodge the complaint after receiving a communication from the Enforcement Directorate (ED). "The information received from ED indicates that the default of Reliance Capital Limited has not been merely the result of commercial or financial distress, but has been preceded or accompanied by fraudulent transactions, diversion of funds and other acts," the complaint stated.

HT

4 dead in Assam after entering water tank; 1 held

SILCHAR: Four people, including three workers, died after allegedly inhaling toxic gases inside an underground water tank at an under-construction building in Assam's Cachar district, police said on Saturday.

The building owner has been detained in connection with the incident, they said. The incident happened on Friday in the Kumarpara area of Jaynagar when workers were engaged to clean the underground water tank, police said.

EC extends SIR schedule for Odisha, T'gana

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission of India (ECI) has extended the schedule for the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Odisha and Telangana after the states' chief electoral officers (CEOs) sought additional time.

According to the July 31 notification, EC has pushed the deadline in Odisha for filing claims and objections to August 19 from the earlier August 4. In Telangana, house-to-house visits by BLOs have been extended till August 10.

Tatkal booking of tickets faster in new site: IRCTC

NEW DELHI: More passengers are now completing Tatkal ticket bookings within the first few minutes after the launch of the revamped Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC) website, according to the government ticketing website.

Citing recent data, IRCTC said bookings done within first three minutes of the Tatkal window increased by over 5%.

{ THE BIG PICTURE }

Theory of everything: Dissent, derision, and demonstrations

Laughter strips power of its pretenses. Caricatures deflate figures of authority. Protests need not be solemn

Now that the streets of the Jantar Mantar neighbourhood are no longer reverberating with sounds and sights labelled obscene and unacceptable by some, it's a good time to analyse the politics of hurt sentiments and sensibilities. Both supporters and decriers of the Gen Z protests against the NEET paper leak have underscored the novelty of the protests — the chants and memes and dances that used ridicule effectively to make a point. Enough has also been said about the essential hypocrisy of those using the excuse of foul language to discredit the protest.

Let's shine the spotlight on the deployment of obscenity in this protest's language first. And let's start from the antiquity, since we are all talking about *The Odyssey* even if we haven't read a word of the poem. One of the most powerful anti-war pieces of literature, *Lysistrata*, was written by Aristophanes in 5th-century Athens, a city synonymous with culture and sophistication. One only has to flip through the pages of his various plays to understand how profanity has always been a legitimate form of protest and everyone is fair game. Aristophanes did not spare even Socrates, one of the founding fathers of the western intellectual tradition, and lampooned him along with other notables of Greek society. He had zero qualms about using vulgar language or sexual references and depictions in his work. Profane language, he rightly understood, is powerful; it is emotional as well as offensive. It allowed him to use absurdity as dissent. This old comedy of Aristophanes laid the foundation for the radical Theatre of Absurd — a movement against the remits of acceptability.

Even William Shakespeare used profanity liberally. Perhaps, if the protestors had used the Bard's colourful language, they might have escaped scrutiny, as few would have understood the meaning. It's the usage of vernacular expletives and colloquialisms that has irked the flagbearers of politeness. They may do well to look up the indigenous traditions of *Nautanki* in the Hindi-heartland, a performing art at the forefront of the Independence struggle in India. The power of the folk invective was unleashed to propel dissent against the British. The audience clapped and cheered heartily whenever the colonisers were called names in a performance. Solidarity was built through a shared parlance of irreverence and ridicule.

Nishtha Gautam

In addition to the verbal ridicule, the Jantar Mantar protest leaned on what celebrated playwright Bertolt Brecht called *gestus* — a powerful combination of body language, social attitudes, and linguistic tone. The majority at the protest may not have heard of either Brecht or *gestus*, but put up a successful epic theatre. The stylised expressions — physical, verbal, and tonal — were clear in their messaging, without evoking any deep emotional response.

Any protest is as successful as the neatness of its performance. The weeklong theatricality of dissent had almost no loose ends. The intent, lampooning the powers that be, was conveyed and received effectively through a shared audio-visual vocabulary that transcended distance through digital media.

Some critics of this student protest have likened it to a *mela*, a carnival. And they are absolutely right. This protest indeed was a carnival, and that's the reason it was successful. Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of the carnivalesque was on full display here. A Babel-like space resonating with innumerable voices, the protest site was a meeting ground for diverse ideas, ideologies, and their respective expressions.

Even silence was a voice to be reckoned with. The very absence of a monolithic idea, a central control room, and order stopped this protest from turning into an ideological cult on the streets. The circus-like energy challenged everyone's presuppositions on what seriousness achieves and to what extent has it already been rendered redundant by a system that becomes serious only selectively, sporadically.

The atmosphere of irreverence and a sense of play, a break from the general solemnity of protests, has also been criticised as a symptom of trivialisation of important issues. But who dares banish joy from dissent? Laughter is a potent tool for registering protest. Nobel laureate playwright and actor, Dario Fo, one of the revivers of the ancient Italian *commedia dell'arte*, used laughter to resist any and all forms of authoritarianism. He also resurrected the spirit of the *giullari*, the medieval jesters, in his works to undermine hierarchies, both in politics and literature. One of Fo's most controversial pieces was *Isabella, Three Sailing Ships and a Con Man*, in which he attempted to, in his own words, "dismantle a character who had been embalmed as a hero in school history books...who tries to keep afloat within the mechanisms of power, play games with the King and be cunning with power figures, only to end up reduced to a wretch". Predictably, he received threats and one of his performances was disrupted by a bomb scare.

Some critics of the CJP protest have likened it to a mela, a carnival. And they are absolutely right. This protest indeed was a carnival, and that's the reason it was successful. REUTERS

Fo began his Nobel acceptance speech by saluting the purveyors of laughter, the jesters — calling himself one — who were once seen as such a serious threat by the enlightened state of Sicily that a law against them was passed in 1221. Fo said, "The law in question allowed any and all citizens to insult jesters, to beat them and even — if they were in that mood — to kill them, without running any risk of being brought to trial and condemned." When speech is curbed with censorship, when jokes beget judicial action, and when comedy becomes a crime, laughter, indeed, becomes the most powerful weapon, especially for those who have nothing else to fight with. Fo's Nobel acceptance speech could very well have been delivered from Jantar Mantar "This absent-mindedness on the part of the young has been conferred upon them by those who are charged to educate and inform them: among the absent-minded and uninformed, school teachers and other educators deserve first mention."

Laughter strips power of its pretenses. Caricatures deflate figures of authority. Protests need not be solemn. Maybe what transpired in Jantar Mantar was a satirical farce, a form that rejects catharsis in favour of keeping the anger and the angst alive. The cause may be sombre, but how it is championed doesn't have to look or sound that. Laughter is resistance at its best and, as demonstrated across time and space, quite effective. If it is offensive now it's because for the first time in years, the monopoly over the profane and the offensive has been challenged. And how!

The views expressed are personal

{ SUNDAY SENTIMENTS }

Karan Thapar

The British ceremonies of PMs demitting office

The British are widely admired for their sense of humour. They have the unique capacity to laugh at themselves. Even their most cherished and beloved are often the butt of jokes. The King — and before that, his mother, the Queen — is frequently mocked in good-natured humour. Their accent, their dress, their mannerisms and even their appearance are joked about. Not for a moment would they object. They know that the jests are proof of their popularity.

What is not so well known is how the British treat their politicians. They can be brutal. Consider what happens when a prime minister (PM) loses an election.

It's customarily held on a Thursday. By the early hours of Friday, the results are known. Around mid-day that morning, the defeated PM drives to Buckingham Palace to resign. He travels in the PM's official car and enters by the main gate. Twenty minutes later, he departs. This time, he's in a car offered by the Palace. Usually, he exits by a side gate. He's now history, and the television cameras no longer follow him.

Shortly afterwards, the leader of the Opposition travels to Buckingham Palace. He does so in his official car. Having been asked to form a government and kiss the King's hands — as the tradition maintains — he leaves in the PM's official limousine.

The whole thing takes about an hour or so. In that short time, one chapter has closed and another opened. One man's tenure is over. Another's has begun.

During this period, removal vans arrive at Downing Street and the outgoing PM's belongings are moved out. The night before, the flat above was his home. The next day by lunch time, it no longer is.

Something very similar happened last month when Keir Starmer ceased to be PM and Andy Burnham took his place. Starmer drove to Buckingham Palace in his official car escorted by outriders. After submitting his resignation, he left by the back entrance, ignored by the TV channels. The sun had set on his day. Minutes later, Burnham arrived, accompanied by his Dutch wife. When he left, he was PM and seated in his official car. Now, the outriders escorted him to Downing Street. Television filmed every moment of the three-minute journey as the country eagerly waited for his first address to the nation as chief executive.

Contrast that with what happens in India. Days can go by after the election results are known before the defeated PM steps aside and the new man is sworn in. That's even the case when the incumbent has won a second term with a full majority.

In America, the newly-elected president has to wait two and a half months before his inauguration. The outgoing president continues as a lame duck during that period.

On the one occasion I remember, when Edward Heath, in 1974, did not resign immediately but sought to form a coalition with the Liberals, there was public anger. The Brits did not like his attempt to cling to office.

Last month, there were a few quaint touches to the Starmer-Burnham transition. Because Buckingham Palace is undergoing extensive maintenance, both Starmer and Burnham entered through the luggage door. The monarch's private secretary and an equerry were waiting for them in the adjacent courtyard. King Charles received them in the Chinese Dining Room. It looked quite exotic.

On arrival at Downing Street, the new PM dispensed with the customary lectern, which is usually placed in the middle of the road, opposite the media, and in front of the new premier's staff, who stand on the pavement. Instead, he spoke extempore. BBC anchors assumed he'd learnt his speech by heart. So traditional had the presence of the lectern become, its disappearance was widely commented upon. That alone ensured Starmer got off to a new start!

WHEN KEIR STARMER CEASED TO BE PM AND ANDY BURNHAM TOOK HIS PLACE, STARMER DROVE TO BUCKINGHAM PALACE IN HIS OFFICIAL CAR ESCORTED BY OUTRIDERS. AFTER SUBMITTING HIS RESIGNATION, HE LEFT BY THE BACK ENTRANCE. THE SUN HAD SET ON HIS DAY

The almost cold-blooded, unsentimental, matter-of-fact way PMs change office in Britain can seem cruel but its clinical, clear-cut and carefully choreographed. How different it is to the scenes played out last week in Delhi.

Karan Thapar is the author of Devil's Advocate: The Untold Story. The views expressed are personal

{ ANOTHER DAY }

Namita Bhandare

Women seldom receive the solidarity they extend

As the crowd surged forward, the police in riot gear on the other side of the barricades, fired water cannons. Metro stations had been shut, but the crowds kept coming, kept chanting: "We want justice."

Memories of the December 2012 protest persist. Then, the anger was over the gang-rape and brutalisation of a young student, inside a moving bus in the NCR. This time, the rage was directed at an exam system repeatedly undermined by paper leaks. Then, the Congress-led UPA government relented, set up a commission and changed the law. Now, the BJP-led NDA government has conceded to demands, set up a commission and has passed an anti-paper-leak bill.

Central to both protests, and all the others in between, have been the presence of women who have unfailingly shown up.

At Jantar Mantar, AISA leader Neha Bora withstood a 23-day hunger strike. Elsewhere, women worked in the medical tents, shouted slogans, fanned protestors, and swept the streets. Every day, women volunteers would arrive, bringing food, water, medicines, and other supplies.

Many young women had come without telling their parents who worried for their safety, not unreasonably, as police swung their batons without regard to gender and also, allegedly, groped and slapped women.

AB came in the evenings after work "like a thief sneaking in and out" because her boss would have sacked her had he known. "I was petrified constantly," she said.

Some of the movement's own messaging left her uncomfortable. Posters that showed Italian Prime Minister (PM) Giorgia Meloni serving samosas alongside PM Narendra Modi serving tea. Posters of Modi in a *sari* — as if being a woman is somehow demeaning. Posters denigrating transgender people as weak and effete, despite the presence of so many who were present.

AB tells me she spoke up against the gendered stereotypes but was shushed by the men around her because, they told her, "This is not the time to raise such objections".

But if not now, when? Women who have participated in marches since the Independence movement, cannot wait indefinitely.

Language reinforces prejudice, and the language a protest chooses is fundamental to the values it upholds. I am not referring to the comments about the "gutter generation" made by BJP MP Kangana Ranaut who seems unoffended by her party's record of "jersey cow" to describe a woman leader in the Opposition.

This is not about a diversionary "bad words" debate but more fundamentally about the language used by a movement that is idealistic and passionate for systemic change. Surely it must realise that being disabled, transgender or female cannot be equated with incompetence and weakness.

In 2012, long after the slogans had died down, women asked what had changed. Yes, women are more likely to speak up. Yes, we have a tougher law. Yes, it's ok to be aspirational. But marital rape is still legal; marriage equality still a chimera. Violence against women is off-the-charts. Dowry and dowry deaths continue, as do "honour" killings. Where are women in Parliament, in the judiciary, in public spaces? Where are we at the protests? Are we just a head count?

In the end, who gains if nothing changes structurally for women? Our bodies must count for more than just bearing the brunt of State repression and troll attacks, or volunteering at protest sites.

The young women at Jantar Mantar have shown they are willing to stand on the frontlines. The challenge now is for the movement to match their fervour and their courage and recognise them as equal partners with an equal stake in the future.

Namita Bhandare writes on gender. The views expressed are personal

English-speaking India's King Lear moment

Some weeks ago, four of us, women aged between 60 and 70, entered a lift at an upscale (but not luxury) housing society on Sohna Road, Gurgaon. We were laughing and talking. The lift stopped mid-way and three little girls came in, with two depressed-looking teenaged maids. One of the girls, aged about six, stared at us and said loudly, 'Look at these old ladies.'

A child that age would not act this way unless she had heard similar sentiments expressed by adults. I shudder to think how the less powerful, such as workers and dependent old people, are treated in such a household.

For decades, I have told American students that Indians do not address older people or strangers by their first names but routinely address them by kinship terms, for which the equivalents in English are 'Aunty' and 'Uncle.' I now need to modify this generalization.

While the practice continues amongst the poor and the middle class, especially those who are not primarily English-speaking, and also amongst somewhat older people across class, it may no longer hold true for the English-speaking upper-middle class youth. In the last two decades, young Indian and Indian-origin stand-up comedians, both in India and in the West, have turned the words 'Aunty' and 'Uncle' into insults.

Comedians and social media videos present middle-class ways of talking and behaving as embarrassing features of older people. Examples include 'uncles' walking, clapping or laughing as forms of exercise, 'aunties' chatting, and older people singing and dancing at weddings. Such behaviour is not considered modern (that is, western) enough.

Those considered modern are the young people we saw at the Jantar Mantar protests, all of them using the filthiest abuses for the Prime Minister (PM) and his deceased mother. Some taunt the working-class policemen on duty, sarcastically calling them 'police uncle,' and one compares soldiers' uniforms to toilet cleaner. A few women from lower-income backgrounds, imitating upper-class women by dressing like them and behaving like them, also spoke like them.

Ruth Vanita

We are used to internet trolls using abusive language while hiding behind made-up names. However, several young women, jeans-clad and fashionable, look confidently into cameras as they voice filthy sexual as well as scatological ideas. One smiles gleefully as she threatens to sodomise the elected PM, who is her grandfather's age, with her slipper.

Every generation has protested and we have all participated in protests. But I have never before heard use such language at a protest. Bias against the old seems to drive this language. Being 'youth' or 'Gen Z' is seen as an inherent virtue. Everyone is young and grows old. Just being young or old is not a sign of being right.

Contempt for the old is not new. Simone de Beauvoir, surveying world history in her 1970 book, *Old Age*, remarks that the old are hidden by 'a conspiracy of silence' and treated as 'a shameful secret.' In the *Mahabharata*, Duryodhana humiliates his blind father and his great-uncle, Bhishma, for being dependent on him. Premchand's story '*Betonwali Vidhwa*' (which I translated as '*A Widow with Sons*') depicts an old woman whose sons grab her property and work her to death.

Laughing at the old becomes a way for the young to bond with each other, and to demonstrate their own upward mobility. SHUTTERSTOCK

Mistreatment of the old used to be somewhat concealed, not flagrantly displayed. Today, English-speaking young people are having a *King Lear* moment, where contempt for the old comes out into the open. Laughing at the old becomes a way for the young to bond with each other, and to demonstrate their own upward mobility.

King Lear is perhaps the ultimate depiction of how the old are mistreated. The two daughters of the king (who is over 80 years old) scornfully label him and his friends 'old' and 'ancient.' Having grabbed his wealth and power, they expect him to need nothing, not even a single attendant. 'Old fools,' says his daughter Goneril, 'are babes again.' She calls her father 'Idle old man,' and refuses to honour her promises. When he protests, she throws him out into the storm, while her sister blinds one old man and physically punishes another. Ordinary people in the play, though, are horrified by Lear's daughters' behaviour. I used to find it hard to conceive of young people, during China's cultural revolution, slapping, beating and humiliating their teachers in public. It is no longer hard to imagine that.

In every society, there are some cruel people. What matters is that cruelty should not become a cultural ideal. In the *Mahabharata*, violence is seen as necessary under certain circumstances but cruelty (*nrishamsya*) is never permissible. Non-violence (*ahimsa*) is not an absolute principle but non-cruelty (*aanrishamsya*) is. Cultural ideals usually change not dramatically but gradually and subtly. We should be alert to such change and resist it.

Ruth Vanita is the author of many books including The Dharma of Justice in the Sanskrit Epics. The views expressed are personal

{ SUNDAY LETTERS }

Conservation not a male domain

This is with reference to "Women are writing new rules for conservation" by Lalita Panicker (July 26). Women today, being aware and educated, are coming forward to put their ideas and use technology in environment conservation. They have made their entry into the stereotype-fixed male domain using their knowledge.

Abhilasha Gupta

The weight resignations carry

This is with reference to "When resignation cleanses and restores lost stature" by Gopalkrishna Gandhi (July 26). Voluntary resignations strengthen democratic accountability, but one taken through public pressure loses ethical significance. Reforms, transparent governance, and institutional accountability ultimately restore public trust.

Sanjay Chopra

II

A resignation should not always be treated as an admission of defeat or guilt, but as an assumption of responsibility and accountability. A resignation adhering to one's conscience and principles can only enhance one's stature.

Gurnoor Grewal

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DMK moves SC on Cauvery water row

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MK Stalin

NEW DELHI: The Opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Saturday moved the Supreme Court (SC) seeking a direction to Karnataka to immediately release Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu and comply with the binding directions issued by the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA).

The move comes even as the Tamil Nadu government is in the process of filing an appeal before the Supreme Court.

The application, filed by DMK Farmers Wing secretary and former MP A.K.S. Vijayan, comes amid concerns over a water crisis in the state during a crucial phase of the agricultural season in the Cauvery Delta.

Pointing out the urgency of the situation, the DMK said, "The present period is the most crucial period of the entire water year for the Cauvery Delta, and it is precisely now that the water is required to flow."

It said the current period is critical for raising the Kuruvai (short-term) paddy crop and for undertaking preparatory and transplantation operations for the Samba (long-term) crop in the Cauvery Delta. "If water is not realised at Biligundlu now, the standing Kuruvai crop will wither before harvest, the ensuing Samba cultivation — the mainstay of the Delta — will equally be imperilled for want of both river flows and groundwater, and the fertile Cauvery Delta, the rice bowl of Tamil Nadu, faces the real and imminent danger of being reduced to a desert," the application stated.

The DMK moved the apex court seeking urgent directions to the Karnataka government to comply with the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) July 28 direction to release 3,500 cusecs of water per day at Biligundlu for 15 days commencing July 29. Karnataka had challenged the order before the CWMA, but its appeal was dismissed on July 30.

The application, settled by senior advocate P Wilson, pointed out that Tamil Nadu had informed the CWRC that Karnataka was not releasing water in line with the Supreme Court's earlier decision as well as a tribunal directing it to maintain a monthly stipulated flow during the months of June to January totalling to 167.25 TMC (thousand million cubic feet). According to the plea, Tamil Nadu had told the CWRC that Karnataka must first release a backlog of about 9.46 TMC.

However, Karnataka opposed the demand and sought that the matter be kept in abeyance, citing acute distress, shortfall in inflows, low reservoir storage, drinking water requirements and conveyance losses.

The DMK claimed that even the CWRC order, later upheld by the CWMA, requiring Karnataka to ensure a flow of 3,500 cusecs per day at Biligundlu for 15 days would aggregate to about 4.5 TMC, which is far below Tamil Nadu's entitlement even on a distress-sharing basis.

It said about 14.913 lakh acres in the Cauvery Delta depend on irrigation from the Mettur reservoir, which in turn depends on flows realised at Biligundlu from water released by Karnataka.

M.P HC CALLS FOR REPORT ON SENIOR CITIZENS' ASSAULT AT SHELTER HOME

HT Correspondent
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BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh high court's Indore bench has taken suo motu cognisance of a widely-shared video clip online showing a minor allegedly beating two elderly women at an illegally run shelter home in the city and ordered a report in the matter.

A division bench of justices Subodh Abhyankar and Alok Awasthi on Friday directed district, civic and social welfare officials to submit a report. "The report must provide comprehensive details regarding the ashram's operations, administrative negligence, the status of necessary permissions, and the actions taken so far," it said.

The purported clip surfaced last week and prompted authorities to seal the home and admit three residents to Maharaja Yashvantrao hospital. Indore collector Shivam Verma said a probe revealed that the home was operating without registering with the social welfare department. An administrative team on Saturday recorded a statement by the shelter home's director Neelam Dubey. Verma said, "An FIR would be registered against Dubey over the alleged encroachment."

Illegal sale of camo cloth busted in Raj

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: In a joint operation targeting the illegal sale of battle fatigues, the Indian Army and Rajasthan Police seized nearly 1,000 metres of unauthorised army-pattern combat cloth from multiple shops in Rajasthan's Sriganganagar town, the army said on Saturday.

The seizure points to a wider network supplying counterfeit military uniforms to vendors in the region, it added.

To be sure, the army earlier secured a patent for a new combat uniform unveiled in 2022 to prevent unauthorised sale and misuse. The new digital camouflage pattern uniform was introduced to address the uncontrolled proliferation of an earlier uniform, which led to security vulnerabilities in military establishments.

> THE ACTION FOLLOWED THE SEIZURE OF SIMILAR COUNTERFEIT COMBAT CLOTH IN BAREILLY IN JUNE

The action followed the seizure of similar counterfeit combat cloth in Bareilly in June this year, which the army traced to a manufacturer in Sriganganagar. "Acting on this lead, Indian Army intelligence personnel conducted a discreet investigation in the city, which pointed to a local firm as a key link in the supply chain allegedly distributing counterfeit Army-pattern combat cloth to shops in Sriganganagar town as well as in Lalgarh Jattan, Suratgarh and other nearby markets," it said.

An interim probe report was shared with Rajasthan Police in mid-July, leading to a coordinated operation on July 30 in which security personnel and police searched multiple shops across the district. Unauthorised possession, sale or use of military-pattern combat cloth is a punishable offence. Such material poses a security risk because it enables the impersonation of armed forces personnel, the army added.

Another reason for selecting the new uniform pattern was to introduce uniformity in soldiers' battle fatigues. Variations in the earlier uniform pattern drew criticism from several quarters. The National Institute of Fashion Technology helped the army finalise the new combat uniform. While soldiers wear the combat uniform in operational areas, those posted at the Army headquarters in New Delhi also wear the combat dress on Fridays in solidarity with personnel in forward areas.

Manju Verma

FORMER BIHAR MIN, HUSBAND TO SERVE 7-YR TERM IN ARMS ACT CASE

HT Correspondent
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PATNA: A special court for MPs and MLAs in Bihar's Begusarai on Saturday sentenced former state social welfare minister Manju Verma and her husband Chandrashekhar Verma to a seven-year jail term in a case concerning the recovery of a large cache of illegally stored weapons from properties linked to her in 2018.

They were also fined ₹50,000 each under Section 25 (1-A) read with Section 35 of the Arms Act, said public prosecutor Ram Prakash Yadav.

The case surfaced after Verma, then a Janata Dal (United) MLA, was linked to the Muzaffarpur shelter home case in 2018.

As part of its probe into the case, the CBI raided Verma's homes in Sripur Arjun Tola and Khanjhapur village and found a 3-0-3 rifle, along with other arms and ammunition.

6 dead as heavy rain batters parts of Kerala

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NEW DELHI: Six people died after heavy rain lashed several parts of Kerala on Saturday, triggering landslides, inundating low-lying areas, swelling rivers and dams.

A statement from the chief minister's office said four out of six deaths occurred in separate landslides in Idukki and Kottayam. Searchs for six missing people are underway, with personnel from the National Disaster Response Force, Fire and Rescue Services, police, the Coast Guard and local administration participating in the rescue operations, the CMO said.

Chief minister VD Satheesan said 17 houses were destroyed and another 127 partial damaged.

Officials identified the deceased in the Idukki landslide as 65-year-old Sumathi from Adoormala and 77-year-old Prabhakaran Nair from Vaikom in Kottayam district. In Kottayam, one of the deceased was identified as Josephine.

Following the landslides and flooding, Satheesan directed ministers in charge of rain-hit districts to camp in their respective districts and coordinate rescue and relief operations. He reviewed the situation with ministers and district collectors.

Meanwhile, three children drowned in separate incidents in Malappuram and Kottayam. In Malappuram, three-year-old Abdul Muhain drowned after falling into the Kandamangalam river near Thiruvali. In another case, four-year-old Adam Aiman drowned after being swept away by a stream in Neerad.

In Kottayam, 11-year-old Milan K Shiju died after falling into a rainwater-filled pit at his house in Pariyaram.

Relief personnel at the site of a rain-triggered landslide in Kottayam on Saturday. PTI

Assam flood toll reaches 82

Assam's Sivasagar, Golaghat, Jorhat, Nagaon and Charaideo continued to reel under flood, with 192,000 people still affected, while two deaths took the toll to 82, officials said on Saturday, adding that around 13,000 people were sheltered in 54 relief camps. Another 26 relief centres were open, catering to 5,384 people. The state is preparing to reopen schools in flood-affected districts by August 10, said chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

ENSURE SISTERS PRODUCED IN COURT: HC IN CONVERSION CASE

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court ordered officials to ensure that two sisters allegedly confined illegally by their father after having voluntarily renounced Hinduism to embrace Islam were produced in court on August 6, and noted that the women were competent to consider life choices.

The bench of justice Sandeep Jain recently noted that any interference by anyone, including their father, would amount to an unwarranted encroachment upon their constitutionally- protected rights to dignity, privacy and personal liberty. The hearing concerned a petition filed on behalf on the two sisters— identified as Divya Bhatia alias Zoya Diya Bhatia (20), and Anshu Bhatia alias Amina Anshu Bhatia (35).

As per the petition, the women chose to act against their father's wishes by converting to Islam and deciding to marry people of their own choice.

Their father, in connivance with local police, illegally confined them, it alleged.

"If these assertions are ultimately found to be correct, any interference by respondent No.4 (father) or any other person in the exercise of such personal choices would amount to an unwarranted encroachment upon their constitutionally protected rights to dignity, privacy, personal liberty, and decisional autonomy," it said. JITENDRA SARIN

India-China border trade resumes after 6 yrs

HTC & agencies
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NEW DELHI: The cross-border trade between India and China through the routes of Shipki La in Himachal Pradesh, Lipulekh Pass in Uttarakhand and Nathu La in Sikkim resumed on Saturday after a gap of six years.

Trade had remained suspended since 2020 due to the COVID-19 pandemic and the subsequent strain in India-China border relations.

In Sikkim, a reopening ceremony was held at Nathula with both nations' participation. Sikkim's commerce and industries department secretary Karma D Youtso said seasonal trade will be conducted from Monday to Thursday until November under the existing bilateral trade protocol.

Indian traders cross into China's Tibet Autonomous Region through the Lipulekh Pass on Saturday. HT PHOTO

"Thirty-eight registered traders have been issued trade passes this year. Around 36 notified items, including handicrafts, handloom products, traditional religious articles, ready-made garments and other approved goods, will be traded through the route," Youtso said.

In Himachal Pradesh, the cross-border trade resumed through Shipki La, known as the ancient silk route joining India with Tibet. State's revenue and horticulture minister Jagat Singh Negi on Saturday flagged off 16 traders and their horses towards Shipki village in Tibet.

In Uttarakhand, a group of 20 Indian traders, accompanied by four helpers, crossed into China's Tibet Autonomous Region through the Lipulekh Pass on Saturday. "The first batch has travelled without carrying any trade goods. The purpose of the visit is to assess the facilities available in Tibet and explore business opportunities to facilitate border trade during the current season," Dharchula SDM Ashish Joshi said, adding that Chinese authorities have allowed entry only to those Indian traders who had left unsold goods in Tibet in 2019 before cross-border trade came to a halt.

He said the traders will visit their godowns at Pulan market in Taklakot, Tibet, where their goods are stored since 2019.

Officials said the border trade season will continue till the end of October this year. However, it may be extended till November if both the Indian and Chinese sides agree to the proposal. The initial visit is expected to pave the way for the gradual resumption of cross-border trading activities through one of the country's oldest traditional Himalayan trade routes.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

MODI IN MYSURU

Swami Vivekananda Cultural Youth Centre — Viveka Smaraka — at the Sri Ramakrishna Ashrama in Mysuru. He said the country's transformation from the constraints of colonial rule to the frontlines of global innovation had been made possible by the capabilities of its young people.

"Today, India is the world's fastest-growing major economy. Who has made this possible? The capability of India's youth. The youth of India are giving impetus to the development of the world," Modi said.

Pointing to the recent launch of a privately built Indian rocket into space, he said the feat reflected "the growing capabilities of the country's young innovators", and that initiatives such as Atmanirbhar Bharat and Make in India were succeeding on the strength of the youth.

What young people needed, he said, was "the right opportunities, guidance and confidence to realise their dreams".

Modi framed the message through Vivekananda, invoking the principle "Shiva Jnane Jiva Seva" — serving humanity is serving God — and urging young Indians to place the welfare of the poor and the nation above personal interests. The Viveka Smaraka, built at the site where Vivekananda stayed during his 1892 visit to Mysuru and from where he decided to travel to the 1893 Parliament of Religions in Chicago, should serve as "a powerful source of inspiration and energy" for that mission, he said.

Opposition parties, meanwhile, attacked the PM for his video message on Friday.

The Congress said the Prime Minister owed the country's students an apology rather than an offer of forgiveness, remarking that while the country was asking the PM to apologise, he had instead "forgiven the country". In a post on X, Rahul Gandhi said Modi had the "audacity to speak of forgiving students" when he had not visited a single family that had lost a child to suicide over what he called a "corrupt" exam system and cancelled papers.

"Nothing is more painful than seeing a parent grieve their child," Gandhi said after meeting affected families during a day-long visit to Tamil Nadu. "Behind every young life lost is a family carrying pain that will never leave them — and serious questions about a broken education system."

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke turned the demand for an apology onto the police action of July 20, when demonstrators marching towards Parliament were met with tear gas and baton charges. In a video posted on X on Saturday, Dipke said he expected Modi to record a fresh message on Saturday night — this time to apologise to the girls who were "brutally beaten up" by male police officers at Jantar Mantar.

"I think Modi ji will upload a new video tonight, so I hope that he will apologise... he will apologise for the lathi-charge of July 20," he said.

Earlier in the day, Modi inaugurated the Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport at Bhogapuram in Andhra Pradesh's Vizianagaram district, which is inspired by the freedom fighter Alluri Sitarama Raju. PM Modi said that it reflects the pride in Indian heritage.

FIFA CONTROVERSY

"anything but transparent."

The reversal comes after the governing regional football body for Europe vowed to boycott the World Cup entirely should FIFA push ahead with the plan, which sought to create an entity to house media rights, including those for the World Cup. Infantino sought to bring in as much as $4.2 billion of outside capital based on a $20 billion valuation for that entity.

UEFA, Concacaf and the Asian Football Confederation argued the proposal had been developed without sufficient consultation and raised concerns that introducing private capital could alter FIFA's governance, priorities and distribution of revenues.

Top European clubs including Real Madrid, Juventus, Bayern Munich and Borussia Dortmund also spoke out in opposition of the monetization plan, putting other FIFA tournaments such as the Club World Cup at risk. Even FIFA's own executives spoke out against Infantino's proposal, with one of them saying he and the organization's staff had been deceived and calling for the proposal to be defeated.

FIFA had argued that the new entity wouldn't privatize the governing body itself, maintaining Friday that it was not "selling football." Instead, it said the vehicle would help unlock greater value from its media and commercial rights while increasing funding for football development programs and distributions to member associations.

Infantino had been promising that each association would receive an additional $12 million in funding for the four-year cycle ending this year, bringing the total payment to $20 million. Members would also have been able to apply for an additional $20 million in funding for long-term projects such as stadiums and training centers.

The investment proposal came after this year's World Cup generated about $1.5 billion in revenue, the most in the tournament's history and with half of that estimated to be profit.

IRAN WAR

understanding with the US on a truce but then quickly "broke it, shot at commercial ships, and killed American soldiers."

"President Trump is not going to stand by and allow this terrorist behavior to occur," Leavitt said in a statement on Friday evening. "Iran will continue to pay until they come to the table in, what President Trump deems, a meaningful way."

Iran hit back at the US.

"The United States is rapidly moving down the path of escalating tensions in the region," said Ali Abdollahi, head of Iran's military central command.

"Any country serving as a defensive shield for criminal and aggressive America will be engulfed by the flames of war," he said in a statement read on state television.

Kuwait's military said on Saturday that its forces were responding to drone attacks, which were part of Iran's assaults on the country.

In a statement, Maj. Gen. Saud Abdulaziz Al-Otaibi, spokesman for Kuwait's Defense Ministry, said the drones hit "a number of vital facilities," including a government structure in the country's north. He said there were no casualties.

The British Navy said Saturday that a tanker was struck and a separate explosion hit close to a vessel in the Strait of Hormuz off the coast of Oman. No casualties were reported in either incident, it said.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Organization (UKMTO) said that an unknown projectile hit the vessel on Friday 11 nautical miles northeast of Lima, Oman. The attack damaged the vessel's engine room.

The group said that on Saturday a large splash and an explosion were reported close to another tanker while it was sailing 21 nautical miles northwest of Khasab city.

Iran has repeatedly attacked vessels attempting to transit through the Strait of Hormuz without its authorization as part of its ongoing conflict with the U.S.

Intense Israeli strikes Friday night and Saturday killed at least four people in central and northern Gaza and wounded dozens more, according to local health officials.

The strikes came after Hamas confirmed Friday that it will disarm in a potential breakthrough for ending the war in Gaza, though major obstacles remain.

Israel has not officially commented on the Hamas deal, which is part of a U.S.-brokered ceasefire announced last October.

That agreement called for Hamas to disarm and hand over power to an independent Palestinian administration. Israel was to withdraw and an International Stabilization Force was to be deployed.

In a post on X Friday, Israeli far-right lawmaker Itamar Ben-Gvir called the deal "unacceptable" and said the killings in Gaza must continue. "Israel must win," he said.

The strikes overnight in Gaza followed evacuation orders by Israel's military. An Israeli military official said it was striking Hamas. The official spoke on condition of anonymity in line with regulations.

Egypt, a key Gaza ceasefire mediator, lauded Hamas and other Palestinian groups for "their positive response" in the phased peace plan, Egyptian state-run media reported.

TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

ANSWERS

1. ₹100 crore
2. Tiger Shroff
3. Ethanol
4. Ballerina
5. Manipur
6. Cocaine
7. De Beers
8. Squash
9. The Odyssey
10. Tomato

MATHURA CROWD MANAGEMENT NOT SCIENTIFIC: HC

Jitendra Sarin
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PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court has issued a series of recommendations to the Uttar Pradesh government to reform the system of crowd management in Mathura-Vrindavan as it observed that the current crowd control system is not based on science.

Taking note of stampede-like incidents in the past, justice Vinod Diwakar sought detailed affidavits from the vice-chairman of the Mathura-Vrindavan Development Authority (MVDA), the district magistrate, the municipal commissioner and the senior superintendent of police.

The bench observed that crowd management in Mathura has largely been reduced to traffic management. "Stampedes and crowd-related incidents at religious gatherings are not merely the result of administrative lapses or inadequate infrastructure but stem from a failure to understand the science of crowd behaviour", it said.

The court passed these directives while hearing a case related to an alleged illegal construction in Vrindavan. The court expanded the scope of the proceedings to address serious deficiencies in crowd management in Mathura-Vrindavan.

U.P. MAN ON RUN AFTER MURDERING 17-YR-OLD SISTER

LUCKNOW: Police in Uttar Pradesh's Sitapur district have launched a search operation for a 22-year-old man in connection with the murder of his 17-year-old sister on Saturday, officials familiar with the matter said, adding that the incident took place days after the teenager was reunited with her family after having allegedly left home with a local man.

The prime accused has been identified as Komal.

An officer said that the victim was allegedly struck repeatedly with a heavy, sharp farming implement after an argument over her relationship with a 23-year-old local man. Two of Komal's associates were detained on Saturday, police said, adding that a case has been registered under relevant sections of the BNS based on the family's complaint. HTC

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

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ACROSS

1 Disgraceful complaint (6)
4 A real sport (6)
9 Short rhyme upheld by Colet (7)
10 Smart girl that is after a share of the proceeds (5)
11 A mouthful of water (5)
12 As enjoyed by a sick celebrity? (3,4)
13 Rose - taken from the garden? (3,1,2,3)
18 Vessel avoided by poor sailors? (7)
20 Worker encountered me coming back first (5)
22 Developed in the wrong way (5)
23 Be keen then disgruntled by employment (7)
24 Not a tough business proposition? (6)
25 Hold out longer? (6)

DOWN

1 Withdraw a direction to surrender (6)
2 Common stock (5)
3 Mount that is dangerous when active (7)
5 Be best man? (5)
6 Chemical container sent up with speed (7)
7 Pin inserted into a joint (6)
8 Rule to which there can be no exception (6,5)
14 Hackneyed tour now rearranged (7)
15 A burden upon the spirit (4,3)
16 One taps a cask with it (6)
17 Turn up at ten on the dot initially (6)
19 One of an opening pair (5)
21 Doctor with practice on computer accessory (5)

QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

1 Prawns fried in breadcrumbs (6)
4 Hypocrisy (6)
9 Be published (4,3)
10 A useful quality (5)
11 To deposit for security (5)
12 Destined to happen (2,5)
13 Alternate (5,6)
18 From beginning to end of (7)
20 Young eel (5)
22 Audibly (5)
23 Baffle (7)
24 Gain by threats (6)
25 Quick (6)

DOWN

1 Reaping hand-tool (6)
2 Carrying a weapon (5)
3 Explorer (7)
5 Mountains in western Russia (5)
6 Instrument of oboe family (7)
7 Assemble (6)
8 Obtained directly (2,5,4)
14 US New England state (7)
15 Make a spectacular profit (5,2)
16 Attack with low flying aircraft (6)
17 Faithful (6)
19 Subordinate to (5)
21 Hold high opinion of (5)

FRIDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17552)

CRYPTIC

P	O	I	N	T	E	D		H	O	S	E	A		
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QUICK

D	I	S	T	U	R	B		O	F	F	E	R		
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{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★

	3		2	8	7			
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1		4			5			3
			6		4			
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9								
8				9	4	1		
			1	7	6		5	

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9X9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ■HIGH ■LOW

SUNDAY	MONDAY	TUESDAY
Generally cloudy sky with Light rain	Generally cloudy sky with Light rain	Generally cloudy sky with Light rain
29°C | 22°C	29°C | 21°C	30°C | 21°C

ALMANAC
Today is 2nd August 2026
18 Safar, 1448
04, Shravana, Krishna Paksha, 04
Samvat 2083
Sunset: Sunday at 06:46 p.m.
Sunrise: Monday at 06:05 a.m.
Moonset: Sunday at 08:57 a.m.
Moonrise: Sunday at 09:20 p.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi	33°C | 26°C
Mumbai	30°C | 26°C
Kolkata	33°C | 28°C
Chennai	38°C | 28°C
Bengaluru	29°C | 22°C

US warns citizens as Iran threatens more choke points

Bloomberg
letters@hindustantimes.com

LONDON/AMMAN/SINGAPORE: US embassies across West Asia urged Americans to exercise caution after Donald Trump said he was considering new military strikes against Iran.

The warning came as Tehran's Supreme National Security Council secretary, Mohammad Bagher Zolghadr, said Saturday that a continued US naval blockade and any escalation would not only further restrict shipping through the Strait of Hormuz but also lead to the closure of other strategic choke points.

Already, the Iran-backed Houthis last week opened a new front in the war, targeting two Saudi Arabian oil tankers in the Red Sea with missiles and drones.

Zolghadr's comments followed a Wall Street Journal report on Friday, citing unnamed US officials, that Trump had ordered the military to carry out a new attack on Iran as soon as this weekend to force Tehran to surrender.

US embassies across West Asia on Saturday warned Americans that they should be prepared for flight cancellations, periodic airspace closures and other travel disruptions as tensions remain elevated.

The stop-start conflict between the US and Iran, which has repeatedly disrupted traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, a key route for oil, liquefied natural gas and fertiliser exports, started February 28. A brief truce collapsed last month, and the two sides paused exchanges of strikes at the end of last week in an attempt to give diplomacy a chance.

That lull ended Tuesday night when Tehran carried out what Trump described as a surprise attack, firing multiple ballistic missiles at a US military base in Jordan. The latest escalation has driven sharp swings in energy prices, with Brent crude ending the week above $90 a barrel, up from below $72 a barrel at the start of last month.

Overnight, an LNG vessel was hit in the Strait of Hormuz off the Omani coast, while a nearby tanker reported a near miss, according to the UK Maritime Trade Operations, which said no environmental impact had been reported. CBS reported separately that the US is considering striking energy infrastructure, including oil refineries and power plants, which would mark a major escalation.

US President Donald Trump with Secretary of State Marco Rubio in a cabinet meeting at Camp David in Maryland on Friday. REUTERS

GOR CALLS ON BANGLADESH TO JOIN PAX SILICA

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DHAKA: US Special Envoy for South and Central Asia Sergio Gor on Saturday discussed bilateral ties, trade and investment with Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and called on Dhaka to join the US-led Pax Silica initiative, local media reported.

In a meeting with PM Rahman at his office in Tejgaon here, Gor said that Bangladesh has significant potential to become a partner in the global economic security alliance focused on critical minerals, energy, semiconductors, and AI infrastructure, the Dhaka Tribune newspaper reported, citing the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Pax Silica, led by the US State Department, aimed to reduce reliance on Chinese tech dominance.

Nirmal Purja among 10 dead in PoK avalanche

Reuters
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KATHMANDU: Celebrated Nepali climber Nirmal Purja, who set a record for the fastest ascent of the world's 14 highest mountains, died in an avalanche during an expedition in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, his company said on Saturday.

"Today it is with profound sadness and immense heartbreak that we confirm that Nirmal 'Nimsdai' Purja tragically lost his life following the avalanche on Broad Peak," his firm Elite Exped said on Instagram. "We also received confirmation that other members of the expedition did not survive," it added.

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah said he was stunned at the deaths of the climbers, including Purja.

"Only physical journey of the climbers has stopped. But the history of their courage, dedication and contributions will always remain alive and inspiring," Shah wrote in a social media post. Purja, 43, and nine others had been missing since Thursday after being struck by an avalanche on the 8,051-metre Broad Peak, the world's 12th-highest mountain, a technically difficult climb in Gilgit-Baltistan.

Officials said the bodies of Purja and other climbers were located in a difficult site and had yet to be retrieved.

Purja, who served in the British military with the Gurkhas and later in special forces, completed his record-breaking feat in six months in 2019. He became widely known internationally after the Netflix documentary chronicling his journey, "14 Peaks: Nothing Is Impossible," was released two years later. The 10 mountaineers were caught in an avalanche around midday on Thursday. Six were Nepalis and the others were from Pakistan, Oman, the US and China.

He was a noted Nepali climber

MORE ROGUE AIs ESCAPED, OPENAI SAYS AS IT WIDENS HACKING PROBE

Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: OpenAI has discovered other instances in which autonomous agents have escaped containment as the firm expands its probe of the hacking incident at tech firm Hugging Face that drew global attention this month, two sources said.

The new breakouts were uncovered during the firm's probe into how one of its agents escaped what was meant to be a contained testing environment this month, the two people said, and OpenAI is now looking into those instances as well.

One of the sources said that the escapes were limited in nature and that none of the agents was thought to have left OpenAI's network.

The discovery of additional rogue behavior at OpenAI could feed growing appetite for regulation coming out of the White House and elsewhere.

Smoke in Kyiv during a Russian missile strike on Saturday. REUTERS

Russia kills 9 as Kyiv appeals for Patriots

Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

KYIV: Russia pounded Kyiv in a heavy ballistic missile attack early on Saturday, killing nine people, as President Volodymyr Zelensky warned that Ukraine had run out of interceptor missiles for its US Patriot air defence systems.

Zelensky said that Russia launched 35 missiles at Ukraine, including 27 ballistic missiles, and also 185 drones. Only one was intercepted, "simply because there are no interceptors for Patriot system", he said.

More than a dozen explosions reverberated through the city during several waves of attacks, according to Reuters witnesses.

"Every package of ballistic missile interceptors saves the lives of our people. And every night without them results in more casualties," Zelensky said on the Telegram app.

TRUMP BEGINS SELLING FAST ACCESS TO HIS SOCIAL MEDIA

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW YORK: Donald Trump knows the world hangs on his every word. Now he wants you to pay for it. His social media posts are going on sale Saturday when his Truth Social business begins offering sneak peeks of them to Wall Street traders willing to pay up. The move raises the prospect of big profits for Trump's firm and big questions about insider trading and using public office for private gain.

Similar fast speed feeds are sold by other social media firms but Truth Social doesn't just distribute the news, it makes it, regularly rattling markets as Trump posts policy changes on everything from war to central bank leadership to tariffs.

"If this was the CEO of a public company, this would be jail time," said Irene Aldridge, head of Able Alpha Trading.

HT

Elon Musk

Musk's fortune falls to levels of pre-SpaceX IPO

NEW YORK: SpaceX pulled off a successful launch last Friday at its Starbase facility in South Texas, sending its Starship rocket into orbit. It hasn't stopped Elon Musk's fortune from falling back to Earth. The world's first trillionaire is now poorer than he was before SpaceX's initial public offering priced last month. Musk's wealth, which peaked at $1.33 trillion on June 16, now stands at $684 billion. BLOOMBERG

Iceland seizes anti-whaling ship and detains crew

LONDON: Icelandic coast guards and special forces seized a ship operated by a group founded by anti-whaling activist Paul Watson and detained its 21 crew members, officials said Saturday. The Icelandic Coast Guard said the crew of whaling ship Hvalur 9 requested assistance on Thursday evening because they believed their safety was under threat from the protest vessel Bandero. It said the Bandero ignored coast guards' instructions to leave Icelandic waters. Along with Norway and Japan, Iceland is one of the only countries still practicing commercial whaling. AP

{ SPAIN } AFTER 67 KILLED IN MIGRANT RUSH

Ceuta border gets new sea barrier

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com

CEUTA: Spain on Saturday installed a 500-metre-long barrier on the sea border between its North African territory of Ceuta and neighbouring Morocco after tens of thousands of migrants breached the frontier earlier in the week.

At least 67 migrants died, including some who drowned and others who were killed in a stampede to cross a breakwater barrier, the Spanish government said Saturday.

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez slammed the reaction of some other EU leaders to the events in Ceuta, saying calls for Spain to be suspended from the EU's borderless Schengen zone were "driven by prejudice."

Most of the 50,000 to 60,000 migrants who entered the territory on Friday soon went back.

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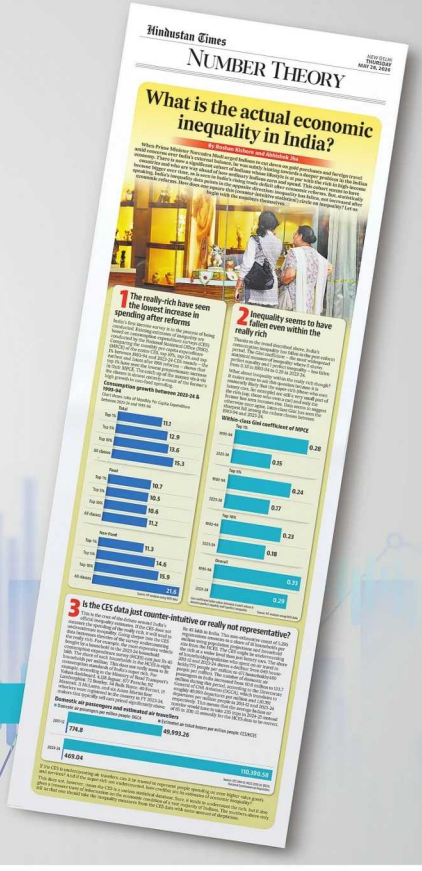

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HT wknd

A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

Anshuman Jhingran

Buoy wonder

The 21-year-old from Navi Mumbai has set a world record: he is the youngest male to complete the Oceans Seven challenge, a set of seven gruelling swims through the choppy waters of the open seas. He has faced crippling hypothermia, the threat of sharks, buffeting currents and an all-consuming loneliness. 'I've learnt that the mind gives up much before the body,' he says. 'And I have learnt patience. If there are problems, I now know there will also likely be a solution'

Shail Desai
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Eight hours into his swim across the Tsugaru Strait, a 19.5-km stretch in Japan, the suffering began.

Water temperatures had dropped to 8 degrees Celsius.

He could see the finish line in the distance, yet he felt like he just wasn't moving. As the accompanying boat drew near to hand him a drink, Anshuman Jhingran stared at his crew and murmured, "Who are you?"

"I didn't recognise them because hypothermia had set in and my brain couldn't process much," says the 21-year-old. "This was unlike anything I had ever experienced. I just kept telling myself: You have to get this done."

It took 12 hours and 40 minutes. When he finally clambered ashore, he had completed the last of his Oceans Seven swims: a feat that involves seven of the most daunting open-water challenges in the world.

He hadn't just finished, either. Jhingran had set a record. He is now the youngest male to ever pull it off. (The youngest-ever is Caitlin O'Reilly from New Zealand, who was 20 when she completed the challenge in 2024.)

"When it was done," Jhingran says, laughing, "there was such relief that I wouldn't have to return to those waters again."

His ability to laugh off a seemingly impossible challenge is, in many ways, how he ended up an open-ocean swimmer.

Jhingran was 15 when a cycling accident near his home in Navi Mumbai broke his wrist and forearm, ending what had been a promising start as a competitive swimmer.

So he'd lost his speed, he thought.

Could he focus on endurance and take to the open waters?

He had no idea what he was signing up for, Jhingran laughs. "I thought it would be a good distraction from all the competing I was missing out on, and far better than sitting at home."

On his first open-ocean swim, in the Arabian Sea, he was stung by jellyfish, which he compares to being electrocuted over and over. His father asked him to consider getting out of the water, but he said he would see the swim through. When he was done, Jhingran says he knew this was something he could throw himself into.

The switch meant he had to retrain his body. He began to spend all day with his trainer at the pool, sometimes starting in the morning and not leaving the water until the sun had begun to set and his pool mates had returned for the evening session.

He had to pile on the pounds, since a higher body-fat ratio helps keep the body warm, makes it more buoyant and provides energy on long swims where nutrition is minimal. Jhingran rapidly gained 20 kg, and faced hurtful jibes.

But all the while, new wins were piling up.

"I told this swimmer who called me a motaa saand (fat bull) that I had just set a record for the youngest person to ever swim the North Channel," he says.

He crossed it at 18, in 2023. That swim, between Ireland and Scotland, marked the launch of his Oceans Seven bid.

He battled real cold for the first time, in waters that were at 13 degrees Celsius (a comfortable pool temperature is about 26 degrees Celsius; normal body temperature is 37). He came face-to-face with moody swells that tossed him about casually, and seemingly bottomless depths.

"The mind gives up much before the body," Jhingran says.

In moments when he felt overwhelmed or afraid, he thought of his parents, homemaker Kiran Jhingran, 55, and financial-services executive Sandeep Jhingran, 56. The hours his mother spent by his side at the pool, caring for him after bouts of intense training. The money his father had poured into his dreams, because he wanted to see his son happy.

> The only time someone is cheering you on is in the first and last few minutes. The rest of the time, you're alone with your thoughts. It can get quite stressful.

He also pictured how painful it would be to abandon the attempt, wasting all the training and effort. These visions kept him going.

As each swim stretched out, his longest over nearly 16 hours, the loneliness, especially in the dark, became something of a demon in the water.

"The only time someone is cheering you on is in the first few minutes and towards the end. The rest of the time, you're alone with your thoughts. It can get quite stressful," he says. "There are times you question all your life decisions: What am I doing here? What made me think I would make it?"

In the great expanse, time often stands still, and it can genuinely feel like one is going nowhere. It's just a dark void below and glimpses of sky as one surfaces to breathe, Jhingran says.

He would break the tedium by singing songs in his head or chanting the Hanuman Chalisa. He would take in tiny details of the boat that moved by his side; and think of the first thing he would eat once he was back on land. His favourite song: Walk Alone by Fearless Motivation. His favourite post-swim meal: a pizza and strawberry ice-cream ("to get rid of all the salt in my mouth").

He would repeat inspiring lines in his head: The devil whispers; you cannot withstand the storm. The warrior replies: I am the storm. "I've had quotes like these in my head for years, and continue to draw strength from them," he says.

By the end of 2024, he had finished four of the seven swims, including the longest: the 42-km, shark-infested Molokai Channel in Hawaii, which took him 14 hours and 21 minutes. Shark repellent works for the great whites, Jhingran says. "It doesn't work as well on the small cookiecutter sharks, so you just rely on luck."

It was eventually the popular 33-km English Channel that posed the most formidable challenge. Jhingran ended up swimming the equivalent of almost twice the distance, because of strong currents. He finished in 15 hours and 49 minutes, his longest bout so far.

"These swims have taught me to be patient, which is an integral part of my life now," he says. "I used to get anxious if I didn't get results immediately. Now I know that if there are problems, there will also likely be solutions."

1 The Oceans Seven challenge involves swims between England and France, Spain and Morocco, Ireland and Scotland, between islands in Hawaii and others in Japan and New Zealand, and between California's Santa Catalina Island and mainland US.

2 Now that he has done them all, Anshuman Jhingran, 21, says he wants to move on. He plans to earn a degree in psychology, and eventually return to competitive swimming.

3 He has developed a unique bond with the seas, he says. "There is still fear, just knowing how big the ocean is and that at some point I am going to be miles from every shore. And knowing that you have to be prepared for anything, from sea animals to giant storms. But the adventure has been a privilege," he adds. "Now, there's going to be no pool for a few months, while my body recovers."

CHECK OUT clips of Jhingran making his way across open-water channels, as part of his Oceans Seven swims

(Above) in the North Channel between Ireland and Scotland, in 2023. (Left) In the Molokai Channel in Hawaii, in 2024.

inside

LIFESTYLE

The new space race

What will the buildings of the future look like? Well, some are already here. Take a look at: a 'mushroom' that merges art and agriculture; an opera house that lets people saunter along its stepped facade; a floating 'oasis' full of classrooms; a mosque with net-zero goals. Tucked into each are tips on new ways forward for us all

CULTURE

This is us: Films for the family

In a world full of distractions, as we quietly lose family lore, a new service offers to make documentaries of your loved ones: quirks, stories, laughter, sketchy memories and all

MIND

The birds and the beeps

When it comes to conservation, might it help to simply listen more closely? By tuning in to clicks, chirps, croaks and calls, bioacoustics researchers are already finding new ways to prevent conflict and protect ecosystems

wknd | lifestyle

The new space race

What will the buildings of the future look like? Well, some are already here. Take a look at dramatic structures now open to the public: a 'mushroom' that combines art and agriculture; an opera house that lets people saunter along its stepped facade; a floating 'oasis' full of classrooms; a mosque with net-zero goals; a church that mirrors a forest. Tucked into each are tips on new ways forward for us all

Gowri S
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For millions of years, we lived on this planet but left no trace we were here.

Tools changed that, and cave art. Then came architecture. Built habitation remains our stamp upon the world; a signature of who we are.

It's not a great scrawl, the one we've been using in recent centuries. Modern architecture's biggest flaws are well-documented: blocky templates replicated over and over, with little thought for local traditions and contexts; price as the greatest determiner, leaving homes and schools, malls and offices darker and dingier than they needed to be; every sq ft capitalised on, shrinking open spaces and green cover.

Now, the urban-density and climate crisis offer a chance to hit reset.

"Cities are the coral reefs of humanity," as Nils Fischer, director of the award-winning UK-based Zaha Hadid Architects (ZHA), puts it. "An expression of the layer cake that human societies are. And their emergence is closely related to the techniques that allowed us to emerge and succeed as a species."

If we think of cities like this, as the built incarnations of societies, he says, they will either become more defensive where hostile conditions emerge — think sea walls, flood protection, water generation, solar protection — or contribute to improving conditions: controlling and reversing sprawl, lowering energy footprint, increasing surface permeability.

"I believe the future in this field will likely be evolutionary rather than revolutionary," adds Neil Gillespie, chair of the Royal Institute of British Architects (RIBA), whose awards recognise excellence globally in this field. "A built environment is a conversation, and the core of that conversation today is the climate crisis. It underpins every discussion about architecture."

What will it take to boost this revolution, and what could hold it back? "The human, and the human," says Fischer. "We are the creators of our own biggest problems, and masters in then solving them. Our history is about erring just a little less often than succeeding."

Featured in this Wknd special are 10 buildings that succeed more than they err, and in doing so, point to a way forward. One was built by ZHA. Two have won RIBA prizes. What they all have in common is that they are soaring feats of construction and imagination, all uniquely responsive to climate, community and place.

Check out new buildings that represent the future, in Bangladesh, China, Italy, Spain, Mexico, Uzbekistan, Albania, Abu Dhabi: a church, a mosque, a township, office buildings, and an opera house with helical gardens on a stepped roof open and accessible to all.

{ 1. TIRANA } ALBANIA

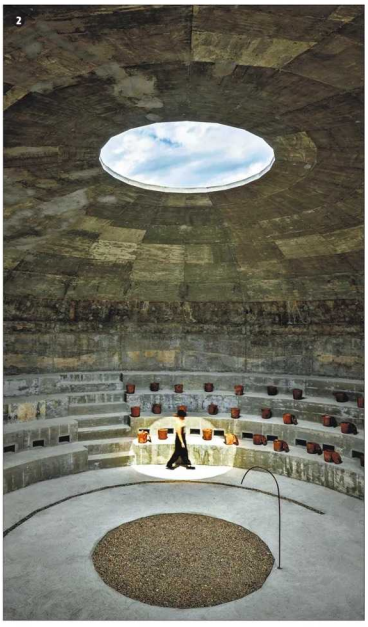
Township made of terracotta

On the edges of Albania's capital of Tirana are homes that offer panoramic views of the city, surrounding forest and mountains. As the city grows, The Nest sets one possible example for the future of this area.

This luxury township, designed by UK-based Zaha Hadid Architects (ZHA), blends into the hillside with curved lines, terraced homes, and terracotta and red stucco facades.

The masterplan involves shaded zones that aim to lower outdoor temperatures in the Mediterranean city, high-albedo surfaces to keep interiors cool, and permeable paving to allow rainwater to percolate.

ZHA, known for award-winning buildings in cities ranging from Rome to Azerbaijan, was set up by the late Zaha Hadid (1950-2016), a pioneer of post-Modernist architecture and the first woman to win the Pritzker Prize, in 2004. The project was announced in June.



{ 2. OAXACA } MEXICO

Mushroom pavilion

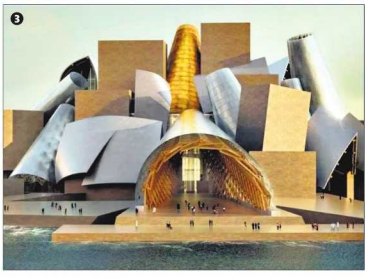
It looks like something from another world: A grey blob in the middle of a desert, set between mountains and a roaring ocean.

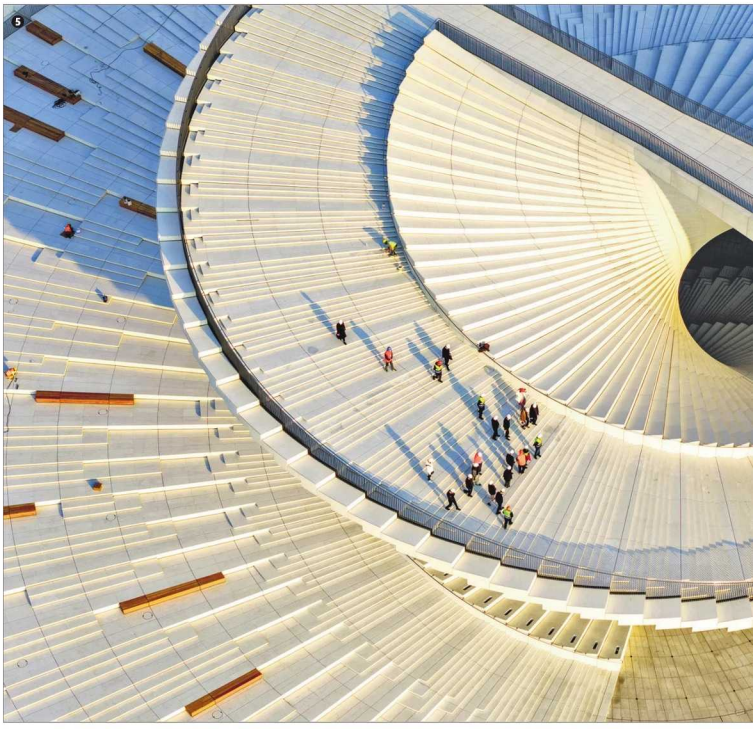
Opened in March, and commissioned by the non-profit arts and cultural foundation Casa Wabi, the Mushroom Pavilion is a dome made of concrete panels fixed around an oculus that allows natural light to flood the space within.

This is where things get interesting. The space within houses galleries for art and allied activity. But all along the walls are rows of terracotta pots growing edible fungi, turning the arts and community space into a functional agricultural site too.

Take a winding staircase up to a rectangular viewing platform and one can look out towards the ocean, and down to where food is growing as a part of the live performance of life itself.

The Mushroom Pavilion was designed by Shohei Shigematsu, partner at the New York-based firm OMA, in an effort to use science, art and activism to interrogate and reimagine how we live.





{ 3. ABU DHABI } UAE

Guggenheim in the desert

This sweeping complex of metal cones and sails is not a single building but a hive of horizontal and vertical galleries, connected by glass bridges and catwalks, planned around a central covered courtyard.

Designed by the late legend Frank Gehry (1929-2025), the 10 cone-shaped structures are inspired by barjeel wind towers (a traditional cooling method that forced hot air upwards and cooler air downwards, over settlements in the desert).

The Guggenheim museum is scheduled to open later this year.

Built on Saadiyat Island, it will sit alongside the Louvre Abu Dhabi, Zayed National Museum, and newly announced Dar Al Funoon performing arts centre (scan the QR code above for views of these structures), raising Abu Dhabi's global image as a hub of contemporary art, culture and tourism too.

While the Louvre Abu Dhabi is the first Louvre facility outside France, this will be the Guggenheim's third museum outside its home country, the US, with the other two being in Bilbao in Spain and Venice in Italy.

{ 4. DHAKA } BANGLADESH

A mosque with net-zero goals

Located in what was once agrarian wetland in Dhaka, the Zebun-Nessa Mosque sits atop a plinth, inspired by the manmade mounds on which traditional homes were built in this flood-prone region.

That's where the similarities with a village home end.

The dramatic curved structure of the masjid, crafted in pink concrete, uses light-filtering motifs across double-layered walls to create a "breathing pavilion" that invites sunlight and ventilation in, keeping energy use low.

Designed by the Dhaka-based Studio Morphogenesis and completed in 2023, the 14,000-sq-metre compound also houses a women's centre, daycare facility and lush landscaping, all powered by solar panels and a greywater recycling system.

For its net-zero goals, innovative design and socio-religious mission, the structure won a RIBA (Royal Institute of British Architects) award this year. "Stripping away ornamentation, Zebun-Nessa Mosque revives the essence of the first mosque, a spiritual, inclusive, ecological, and deeply social space," the RIBA citation notes.

(It is) a spiritual, inclusive, ecological, and deeply social space.

The award citation by RIBA

{ 6. HANGZHOU } CHINA

Blue ribbons of glass and water

It has taken six years to build the Grand Canal museum in Hangzhou, with its rippling glass facade that mirrors the world's oldest and longest artificial river.

Work on it is expected to conclude this year.

The "manmade river" it celebrates is the 1,794-km north-south Beijing-Hangzhou Grand Canal, parts of which are more than 2,500 years old.

The canal still helps fuel agricultural, economic and cultural development across a massive region. In addition to carrying water across flat plains, and now urban skylines, it helps move massive stores of grain and goods from wealthy southern agricultural regions to political centres in the north.

"The water and the museum face each other, creating a visual and material dialogue between the subject and its narrator. The museum is reflected in the water and the water in the museum's facade," said a statement released by Swiss architecture firm Herzog & de Meuron, during the unveiling of the design in 2020.

The firm achieved this reflection with a design that isn't just linear, but also floats about 13 metres above ground level, supported by concrete cores and steel columns.

The space beneath the grand museum will serve as a public plaza, while open-access rooftop walkways and a sky garden will offer elevated views of the ancient canal.

{ 5. SHANGHAI } CHINA

An opera house, a park, and a lookout point

Designed by the Norwegian firm Snohetta, the 10-storey helical facade of the Shanghai Grand Opera House is a unique affair.

Inside, three auditoriums serve as performing-arts venues.

Outside, the façade itself forms a massive stepped space that will serve as a free, 24-hour lookout point and park.

"The helical roof mimics an unfolding fan, an ode to the dynamism of performance and the human body," Snohetta founder Kjetil Traedal Thorsen says. "The radial movements of the roof form a spiral that connects ground and sky, while offering views of the city and Huangpu River. It is designed to promote the idea of public ownership of the building."

Eventually, the plan is for the stepped facade to host events too. The space is scheduled to open in October.

{ 7. DHAKA } BANGLADESH

From landfill to green university

It took seven years to turn a 5-acre landfill in Dhaka into a plot ready for a uniquely green university.

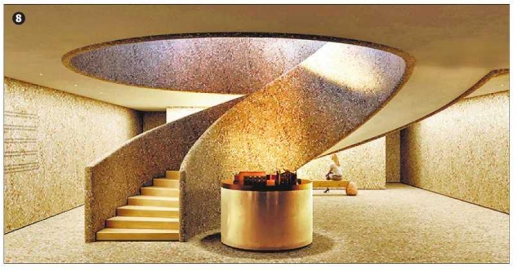
Completed in 2024, the BRAC campus has classes and other educational spaces that "float" in a 13-storey vertical oasis. Here, horizontal breezeways drive natural cross-ventilation through the privately run research university.

Expansive green walls and garden terraces house vertical landscaping systems and bio-retention ponds that have won the structure a RIBA (Royal Institute of British Architects) international award for excellence.

The ground level is a park that is open to the public, and uses porous paving as part of an ongoing effort to naturally regreen and regenerate this once-toxic site.

Rainwater runoff is channelled towards a lake that was allowed to form, through the initial seven years, in the spongy depression at the heart of the plot.

BRAC University was designed by the Singapore-based studio WOHA.



{ 8. TASHKENT } UZBEKISTAN

An art hub in a 114-year-old tram depot

A 1912 tram depot and diesel station has been painstakingly restored and transformed by the Paris-based Studio KO into the first permanent centre dedicated to contemporary arts in Uzbekistan.

The exposed-brick framework and industrial character of the structure were retained, with the expansive emptiness now serving as large exhibition spaces. Details in glazed ceramic serve as a nod to Central Asian handicrafts, while light-filtering motifs aid in ventilation and cooling, and are a nod to local building traditions and local Islamic culture.

What is now the Centre for Contemporary Arts was, incidentally, the home of Tashkent's first-ever tram line, making this repurposing by the NGO Uzbekistan Art and Culture Development Foundation a key heritage initiative.

The foundation has two similar efforts underway at nearby sites, with plans to convert a 19th-century timber-framed madrassa and a former kindergarten into artist residencies, with the support of the Aga Khan Foundation. Together with the contemporary-arts centre, which opens in September, this will create an art district within a heritage hub where there was simply neglected heritage before.

{ 9. MILAN } ITALY

Glass meets ice at the Santa Giulia arena

Built as an ice-hockey venue for the 2026 Winter Olympics held in February, this 16,000-seat arena in Milan — a cylindrical building composed of three rings at different heights, connected by transparent glass bands — is now the largest arena in Italy.

As of May, the Santa Giulia has been open to concerts and festivals too. But the real highlight is the 10,000-sq-metre public space that wraps all around the facility.

A collaboration between two UK-based firms, Arup and David Chipperfield, the arena is meant to echo the elliptical form of the Ancient Roman amphitheatre. The wraparound public space mirrors the piazza.

The Santa Giulia is part of a new urban district that is rising in Milan as the result of a massive redevelopment and reinvigoration plan.

As recently as 2003, this was an industrial area dotted with defunct steel and chemical units. It is now a mixed-use neighbourhood of homes, office spaces, malls and cultural venues, with many of its cycling paths and pedestrian walkways leading to a lush central park.

{ 10. BARCELONA } SPAIN

Sagrada Familia, a living cathedral

For nearly 150 years, this Gothic marvel has famously, and slowly, been rising over the city of Barcelona.

In February, a white cross was placed atop one of its 18 towers, officially making this the tallest church in the world. In June, Pope Leo XIV visited the cathedral to mark the death centenary of its designer, the Catalan architect Antoni Gaudí, and performed a solemn mass, thus officially opening La Sagrada Familia.

The church was born of a grand dream. Gaudí envisioned a temple that resembled a forest, with branched columns, dramatic spires and Gothic detailing.

Construction has been overseen by the La Sagrada Família Foundation, with different architects and firms collaborating.

As the timeline of 10 years stretched out through his life (and far beyond; he took on the project in 1882 and died in 1926), Gaudí would famously say "My client," referring to God, "is not in a rush."

Many in Spain have nonetheless been enraged over the man-hours and expense dedicated to the project. Others see it as one of humanity's great endeavours.

It is no longer clear how much of Gaudí's vision actually lives on in the cathedral. Given that plans have been lost in wars and damaged by anarchists over the years, it is a labour of love that is fittingly no longer attributable to one man alone.

SHUTTERSTOCK

culture

This is us: Films for the family

In a world full of distractions, as we quietly lose family lore, a new service offers to make documentaries of your loved ones: quirks, stories, laughter, sketchy memories and all

(Clockwise from above) The Sharmas on their family trip to Varanasi; Shiv Shankar Sharma with an image of his younger self; a still from the documentary on the Mehras. IMAGES COURTESY FAMDOCS COLLECTIVE

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"Do you remember that story Dadu used to tell," can be a heart-breaking question when the grandfather is no longer around to answer it. In this way, we quietly lose family lore, treasured memories, and all the details we didn't listen to hard enough.

Most are tales no one else now knows: About the uncles who got lost in a forest while on holiday, and claim to have come face to face with an elephant. The power outage that led to a valiantly fought game of antakshari. The parents who watched their daughter take her first steps in their under-construction house, the smell of concrete and paint still hanging in the air.

Last year, copywriter-turned-filmmaker Robbie KCee decided to launch a service that could help. Famdocs makes documentaries about regular families.

Clients pick their subjects and choose an ideal runtime. He then turns up to document the subjects' day, capture unscripted moments, and conduct interviews in which they may unpack heirlooms, pore over photo albums, sing or play a musical instrument, as their mood dictates.

He then edits the footage, adds music, and hands over a 30- to 40-minute film. (Prices start at Rs 5 lakh for a film and Rs 1.5 lakh for a Famvoice video featuring just one person.)

"We're all connected constantly, but not really," says KCee, 42. "We've stopped really talking and listening to each other."

It was regret about this that led to the idea for Famdocs. His daughter Hosanna, he says, was full of questions about his mother, who had died a decade earlier.

"As I told Hosanna stories of her, I found myself really wishing I had recorded the things she used to say," he says. "So this is a chance to record a loved one: quirks, laughter, sketchy memories and all."

It helps, he adds, to have an outsider do it. "We have no family baggage. We don't have our own perspective on the stories. The result is a video that aims to capture the essence of who this person is, and perhaps even who they are when you're not around."

He, cinematographer Kartik Thapliyal and producer Sujitha Menon, have so far shot four documentaries and about a dozen Famvoice videos.

While the single-subject Famvoice is shot over one day, the full-length film takes considerably longer. The crew typically spends a few hours talking to each subject, mapping their lives, hobbies, habits and quirks, and chatting with them in their natural setting. "On this first day, we might capture them going about their day, to the bazaar or for a drive around town. Then, once they're comfortable, each subject sits down for a one-on-one chat," KCee says.

It generally takes about four days to get all the footage they need. Slowly but invariably, moments of laughter, and tales of little joys and sorrows spill out.

That's a wrap

In one documentary, shot during a 50th-wedding-anniversary family trip to Varanasi, Shiv Shankar Sharma and his wife Manju Sharma, their children and grandchildren take turns recounting another trip, when a horde of adults and children crammed into Shiv Shankar's boxy red van.

Everyone remembers the day they packed 14 people into the vehicle. As his daughter Kamna Sharma, now 38 and a marketing executive, chuckles at the memories, he starts to talk about how he still misses the van. "It was stolen years ago. I never would have sold it," he says. "We now drive around in a BMW and a Fortuner. I don't really enjoy these cars as much."

In another documentary, the Mehras from Gurugram, a couple in their 60s, are at what they call their weekly kar-o-bar meet, driving to late-night food stalls with friends and eating either in their car or at a local dive. Their children, settled abroad, decided to document their daily lives as a gift they could all share in.

On Instagram, meanwhile, KCee's samples tend to feature stories told by willing friends. Marketing executive Himanshu Gaur, 47, tells one about his "zen mother", now-retired schoolteacher Rajul Gaur.

Maggi's instant noodles had just entered the market in the 1980s, he recalls.

Once he had tasted them, he decided this was all he would ever eat. Instead of losing her cool or cracking the metaphorical whip, his mother simply said "Okay", and Gaur ate the noodles for two days straight. "By the end of that second day, when she handed me Maggi again, I was so done," he says, laughing. "I wanted rajma-chawal again!"

The pragmatic Indian parent hasn't changed, KCee adds, laughing.

Many are horrified when they hear how much a child is paying in order to have a stranger record them as they tell the "same old stories".

"They truly don't understand it. Sometimes the kids try to explain by saying that it's like a pre-wedding shoot. That doesn't always help," he says, laughing. "They're still aghast: A pre-wedding shoot for your grandparents?!"

{ DEE FOR DRAMA }

Deepanjana Pal

Seeing red

Star City tells tales from within the Soviet-era space programme, blending fact and fiction to offer a truly bingeworthy series

What if the Soviet Union had won the space race in 1969? That is the premise of the series For All Mankind (2019-), in which creators Ronald D Moore, Matt Wolpert and Ben Nedivi imagine a world in which America is forced to play catch-up after Soviet Russia sends a man to the moon.

The series is fantastic sci-fi. So it's surprising that the new spin-off, Star City, belongs to an entirely different genre: forgotten heroes.

Created by the same team of Nedivi, Wolpert and Moore, Star City is the Soviet side of the story, with more espionage and less stargazing. While space plays a critical role, most of the drama is earthbound.

There is espionage, star-gazing, an autocratic government, and a host of truly incredible performances.

The two poles of the plot are chief designer Sergei Korolev (Rhys Ifans) and Colonel Lyudmilla Raskova (Anna Maxwell Martin). He heads the Soviet space programme. She works with the KGB. The two butt heads when Raskova learns there is an American mole on Korolev's team.

Everyone has secrets here, and the state exerts its autocratic power ruthlessly. Yet resistance bubbles up in unexpected places.

The taut spy thriller often feels reminiscent of Chernobyl (2019). Although it isn't as brilliant, the performances are uniformly excellent, and world of the show is realised beautifully by production designer Paul Spriggs. Brendan Uegama's cinematography is breathtaking and Star City benefits from some brilliant editing.

The script frequently tips its hat to historical figures and events, blurring the lines between fact and fiction. An engineer named Sergei Korolev really did lead the Soviet space programme, for instance, though he died in 1966 (having spent years in a gulag during the Stalin years).

Star City also includes a nod to the historical camaraderie with India, through the character of Lakshmi Chadha (Priya Kansara), who joins the team on a secret mission. In a rare accomplishment for Hollywood, and a welcome change, the Hindi dialogue doesn't sound like it was written by a bot.

While it does occasionally lose its way in the last two episodes, I found Star City to be one of the most bingeworthy shows of the year so far. Through the lives of its cosmonauts, engineers and office workers, it examines ideas of heroism, patriotism, dissent and loyalty. Like all the best speculative fiction, it is a flight of fantasy rooted in frustrations and anxieties that are only too real.

(Write to Deepanjana Pal @dpanjana on Instagram. The views expressed are personal)

wknd | mind

The birds and the beeps

When it comes to conservation, might it help to simply listen more closely? By tuning in to clicks, chirps, croaks and calls, bioacoustics researchers are already finding new ways to prevent conflict and protect ecosystems

Rohini Nilekani
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Have you heard recordings of the otherworldly sounds of whales?

I was fortunate to hear for myself the click-clicking of sperm whales, as a pod with two youngsters swam alongside us in the open Caribbean Sea. Tears overwhelmed my snorkel mask. I felt humbled and grateful for these gentle giants of the ocean, gliding peacefully beside us humans, despite so many threats from our species.

As the world wakes to the urgency of saving the 90-plus cetacean species roaming global waters, understanding how they communicate becomes critical to preventing harm, especially from marine vessels. This is where the emerging field of bioacoustics comes in.

The K Lisa Yang Center for Conservation Bioacoustics at Cornell University's Lab of Ornithology is the only one of its kind in the world. Recently, Lea Bouffaut, a researcher there, co-authored a study showing that undersea fibreoptic cables can be repurposed as never before, to listen in to marine life using distributed acoustic sensing.

The shipping industry must listen in too. After all, more than 20,000 whales are killed each year by ship collision alone.

Many such examples were cited when Lea and Yang Center director Holger Klinck visited Delhi for a meet on the need for a bioacoustics centre in India.

At the meet, spearheaded by Robin Vijayan and his team at the Indian Institute of Science Education and Research (IISER), Tirupati, the room held representatives from academia, government, industry and philanthropy. A day-long discussion highlighted ways in which this field could aid wildlife conservation in India.

Call and effect

Though it originated a century ago, not too much is known about conservation bioacoustics.

It is the interdisciplinary study of sounds in nature, to understand and eventually protect species and ecosystems. Since the 1920s, when simple recorders were used to collect and analyse insect and bird calls, improvements in sensors and now AI have given the sector a boost. Today, it finds widening application in environmental sciences and in medicine.

Bioacoustics is used in cardiac surgery, targeted drug delivery and tissue engineering. In the environmental sciences, it is helping researchers "listen" to plants. Among their findings: stressed root systems may emit detectable ultrasonic clicks.

The science has for a while now been used to eavesdrop on birds. The Merlin and eBird apps developed at Cornell offer real-time sound identification, based on call or song. eBird has famously become the world's largest citizen-science data project. Anybody with a smartphone can use these apps to discover the joys of birdwatching, while feeding into a diverse people's conservation movement.

In just one year, 2025, Merlin users recorded 1.36 billion bird sounds. These will feed into the third State of India's Birds report, due out next year, which will again inform the country of the plight of its 1,350 species (and counting). Recently, a sound recording of the critically endangered Jerdon's courser, last seen in India in 2008 and feared extinct, created a massive buzz in the birder community.

Sound investment

There is so much bioacoustics can be used for in India. It could help us understand animal behaviour, prevent human-animal conflict and enhance biodiversity.

The government of India has internationally acknowledged commitments on the protection of the environment, including the adoption of the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, which calls for halting and reversing biodiversity loss by 2030.

To conserve, we must monitor. So far, we are heavily dependent on imaging. If we added bioacoustics, we would gain new levels of data and precision. Newly developed Autonomous Recording Units (ARUs) could map coral reefs and dense forests where humans cannot go.

CAMPA (the national Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority) has unused funds that could be used to create new protocols for bioacoustics deployment in India. Sophisticated sensors could help track how wildlife returns, for instance, to areas where invasive species are being removed at scale.

Biodiversity is India's strategic advantage and we should do all we can to push it.

Most importantly, bioacoustics is a key component of early warning systems to prevent human-wildlife conflict, which is rising across India. Understanding where elephants are trumpeting, tigers roaring and wild pigs snorting could enable early action to prevent human injury and death, and prevent crop loss, which is estimated at more than Rs 10,000 crore annually just in Maharashtra. Indian airports, meanwhile, recorded 6,337 bird-hit incidents over the past five years. Bioacoustics could help analyse and broadcast natural communication signals to keep birds from an aircraft's path.

India could make the journey more affordable by building its own manufacturing capacity, perhaps with help from the government's Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF). We have the technical capability to harvest and analyse the data that would emerge, using the latest AI tools. We have the academic backbone in the environmental sciences and the societal muscle to support the deployment of bioacoustics across critical use cases.

The time is right to listen anew to the heartbeat of our country's flora and fauna. If we succeed, we can marvel not just at the music of songbirds and whales, but the crosstalk of trees and plants. As our ancestors put it: Vriksho rakshati rakshitah. Nature protects those who protect it.

(Rohini Nilekani is chairperson of Rohini Nilekani Philanthropies and author of Samaaj, Sarkaar, Bazaar: A Citizen-First Approach)

(Above) Artwork created for the bioacoustics convention in India. (Below) A researcher records elephant sounds at Kaziranga National Park. ILLUSTRATION: MAYUR NANDA/ COPYCAT DESIGNS; PHOTO: VIJAY BEDI

{ LIFE HACKS }

Charles Assisi

Age against the machine

We call it ease of use, and revel in the speed and instant results. But is it 'ease' if millions of people – our elders – are left out in the cold?

Mum's set-top box went on the blink last week.

She lives in Fort Kochi, and I was on a work call in Mumbai, when a cousin who lives in Bengaluru began to call persistently. He is the tech-head every elder in the family turns to when in need. How was I to know he was calling because he needed an OTP?

The OTP expired and we had to start the rather torturous process of trying, across three cities, to prove our authenticity as users and resolve the issue online.

Fixing such issues now involves an app that my 75-year-old mother cannot use on her own. Simply logging in is a challenge. The app demands an email address she did not choose, a user ID she never wrote down, and an OTP that travels all the way here, to my phone in Mumbai.

The whole thing became so complicated, we were soon on a conference call. Her voice was thin with the effort of holding the phone while trying to follow instructions. As my cousin guided her through menu options on the set-top box, I hunted for her user ID. As time ticked on, early attempts failed, and all three of us began to sound exasperated.

When the TV finally flickered back to life, the relief in mum's voice was mixed with other emotions: frustration at being forced to call us during our work hours; embarrassment at being unable to deal with an everyday issue; and a quiet anger at a world that has become so unrecognisable, it has forced her into this position of dependence.

OTPs time out, passwords must be changed, details verified in seconds. We're cutting too many pieces out of the picture. (Above) Ted Danson in Man on the Inside (2024-).

I celebrate Digital India because it has made things just so easy. I enjoy the frictionless-ness of being able to complete such tasks in seconds, without leaving the home.

As my mother's frail voice came over the phone, though, I allowed myself to feel how frightening and alienating this must be for her. So much now involves an OTP, "quick" online form or new user registration: paying bills, renewing a passport, ordering a gas cylinder, getting the TV back on.

Hers is a generation that prided themselves on buying their own homes, building up their savings, caring for their nuclear families. How lonely must it be to suddenly feel like one is outside it all, unable to type the OTP in quickly enough; seeing the timer run down and knowing one must now start all over again, while impatient younger relatives wait on the line for you to get it right.

Each failed attempt must feel like a small humiliation.

Nandita Abraham, a dean at the BITS Design School, puts it plainly: "It is the role of a designer to design for people who are 75 or older. This applies to how many seconds an OTP is given, or what happens when an older person has to log into an app under pressure and cannot remember their password. The designer has to know all the people they are designing for, and account for them."

Sadly, that isn't how the world works.

The systems that govern my mother's set-top box, bank account and electricity bill were built by people who, like most young people, seem to think they will never feel 75, or struggle with what anxiety can do to memory under a ticking clock. They think, as most of us do, that we will never know the loneliness of needing something urgently and having to turn to busy younger people, far away, for help.

We have allowed technology to redefine competence, relevance and care, in ways that — when one looks at them closely — are quite brutal.

In Kochi, the set-top box works again. When it freezes next, the cycle will repeat.

The world will not slow down. All we can do is choose whether the people who raised us are left standing on the edges of it all, or whether we can make room for them too.

That choice, more than any app update, is the upgrade that matters.

(Charles Assisi is co-founder of Founding Fuel. He can be reached on assisi@founding-fuel.com. The views expressed are personal)

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{ TRADE-OFFS } THE HIGH PRICE OF KEEPING SERVERS COOL

Watt it's worth: Why AI data centres run hot and drink deep

Mridula Ramesh

Erin Brockovich, the environmental campaigner immortalised in the Oscar-winning film, is digging into AI data centres. This week, I'd like to explore why.

Heat: A feature, not a bug

AI's story began nearly 80 years ago, in the offices of Bell Labs, with the invention of the transistor.

At its simplest, a transistor is a microscopic switch made from silicon. Think of it as a sandwich, where a slice of "receiving" silicon is placed between two slices of "giving" silicon, with a gap of insulating material in-between. Apply a little voltage and a bridge opens up, and electrons begin to flow from the giving to the receiving silicon layer, turning on the transistor.

Moving electrons generate heat. Seen this way, a transistor is like a tiny heater powered by electricity.

Engineers pack these transistors onto chips — thin pieces of silicon that resemble miniature cities, with transistors as buildings, wires as roads, electrons as traffic, and clocks as traffic lights that work to keep everything in step. The Intel chip in my laptop contains more than a billion transistors: an entire miniature city of tiny heaters.

But chips, like cities, come in different forms.

The CPU (central processing unit) is a generalist: it can open a browser, check email or play music, handling tasks as directed, in careful sequence. The GPU (graphics processing unit) is a specialist. In its early days, it drew the millions of pixels needed for videogames by performing many similar calculations simultaneously.

It turns out this works brilliantly for the math behind AI, which involves multiplying vast grids of numbers to train and run models. Nvidia, the company most closely associated with GPUs, has unsurprisingly become the rockstar of the AI world.

Chips, along with memory, storage, networking, power and cooling hardware, are packed into servers. Servers are stacked in racks. Racks together make a data centre.

A conventional data centre, running websites or cloud storage, relies largely on CPUs, and an average rack in such a centre draws about 8kW. In an AI data centre, GPUs do the heavy lifting. A high-density AI rack can draw over 2,000 units of electricity a day at 80% utilisation.

A large AI data centre can therefore consume millions of units daily.

Nearly all that electricity ends up as heat. Rack for rack, a cutting-edge AI system can emit about 14 times as much heat as the average conventional rack.

An AI rack is, in effect, a 120-kW electric heater that happens to answer questions.

High electricity use and heat generation are a feature of AI, not a bug.

Energy

All told, how much electricity are we talking about?

According to the International Energy Agency, data centres consumed 415 TWh in 2024, enough to meet the average annual needs of 353 million Indian households.

There is good news here, with a caveat.

Many leading hyperscalers advertise their vast purchases of renewable power as proof of corporate virtue. But renewable energy did not spring fully formed from capitalism's generous heart. It was helped along by subsidies, regulation and decades of political pressure over climate change.

That is precisely how markets are supposed to work: governments set a direction and draw a line around what is no longer acceptable, and capitalism gets to work, finding progressively cheaper ways to meet the constraint.

Hyperscalers in India have bought a lot of renewable energy (and offsets) to power their centres. But to someone familiar with the innards of electricity adjustment, the relative opacity in how they match seasonal and diurnal generation with constant use invites further scrutiny.

If we as a country are subsidising that cost (through generous policy support), what precisely are we getting in return?

Water

All this electricity, turns to heat.

On a visit to one such centre, Joanna Stern, reporting for The Wall Street Journal, said it was hot enough around the servers to "blow-dry my hair".

Cooling involves two separate tasks: lifting heat away from the chips and servers, and ejecting it from the building. The first can be done in several ways: by blowing cold air through servers; through direct-to-chip cooling, in which cold plates sit on GPUs and a sealed liquid loop carries heat away. The latest is immersion cooling, in which servers are submerged in a non-conducting liquid that absorbs their heat.

Once the heat reaches the edge of the building, it can be ejected through dry coolers that use little or no water; through evaporative cooling towers, which can consume about 1.5 to 2 litres per kW-hour of computing electricity; or via a hybrid of the two.

Thus, depending on the combination of technologies and the local climate, a 100 MW AI data centre can consume almost no onsite water for cooling — or over 2 million litres a day.

Which brings us to an inherent trade-off underpinning data centres.

Water usage effectiveness, or WUE, measures litres of onsite water consumed per unit of computing electricity. Power usage effectiveness, or PUE, compares the electricity used by the entire facility (including cooling infrastructure) with that used by its computing equipment.

Dry cooling can lower WUE, but often raises PUE, increasing electricity consumption and the remote water footprint of compute. A low WUE, therefore, can be a misleading badge of virtue: it may simply move the water burden from the data centre's cooling tower to a distant power station.

Studies have shown that the offsite water footprint of data centres far exceeds what is used onsite.

Indeed, the United Nations University Institute for Water, Environment and Health estimates that in 2025 the electricity consumed by data centres carried a water footprint of 4.5 trillion litres, most of it embedded in the water footprint of the electricity used in data centres.

In 2025, according to its own sustainability report, Google alone consumed 41 billion litres of water, 97% of it in its data centres — enough to meet the annual water needs of nearly two million Indian households (assuming an Indian needs about 135 litres of water per day).

Google says its projects replenished water equivalent to 78% of its freshwater consumption in 2025. Such accounting matters, and can catalyse useful innovation.

In Uttar Pradesh, the company is funding precision drip irrigation, measuring the water saved and creating an incentive for farmers to use less; it is also restoring lakes and watersheds across India. Having interacted with many of the organisations doing this work, I know that it is far from nothing.

But replenishing water elsewhere does not erase extraction from the watershed around a data centre. That matters particularly because a Bloomberg analysis found that many new data centres are located in stressed watersheds. In India, most such facilities are coming up around Mumbai and Chennai — neither renowned for their water security.

Meanwhile, what lies unspoken may be far more revealing than what is reported.

Amazon says Amazon Web Services consumed just 0.12 litres of water per unit of computing electricity globally in 2025; however, its Asia-Pacific operations outside China averaged 1.10 litres — more than nine times as much. Climate possibly explains some of the difference, but it's unclear from the reports what role climate played, and what came down to technological choices.

AWS also claims water positivity in India and has repeatedly said some of its Indian data centres use no water for cooling. Yet the same regional factsheet says AWS withdrew more than 383 million litres in Mumbai in 2025, and more than 56 million litres in Hyderabad. Where was this water used? How much was consumed (versus merely withdrawn)? Offsite or onsite? The lack of clarity is a big part of the problem.

Tell it like it is

As Brockovich has said, what angers communities is not only the resources used but also the secrecy surrounding it all.

Communities in the US complain of water pressure drops, muddy water and wells running dry — inconveniences familiar to anyone living above a draining aquifer. Add to this noise, heat and, in parts of America, higher water and electricity bills.

And what do communities get in return?

The lure of "jobs" seems hollow on closer inspection: Hundreds of construction jobs (thousands at the largest sites) may appear briefly, but many go to migrant workers rather than local residents. Once construction ends, a 100 MW AI data centre may consume the electricity of a small city, yet employ only about 60 people onsite. (The engineers who design and manage the AI systems usually sit elsewhere.) So the benefits are dispersed and often distant, while the demands for land, water and electricity are intensely local.

The outrage over this is spreading. Last month, the US reportedly saw an unprecedented 142 demonstrations against AI data centres. Similar opposition has surfaced in Chile, in Europe, and even in Thane.

Something has to give.

(Mridula Ramesh is a climate-tech investor and author. She can be reached on tradeoffs@ctr-maction.net. The views expressed are personal)

(Above) Vapour rises as a result of cooling operations at an AI data centre campus along the Columbia River in Oregon. (Below) A server room. Rack for rack, a cutting-edge AI outfit can emit about 14 times as much heat as the average conventional system. ADOBE STOCK

Boxers pack a golden punch to boost India's medals tally

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Indian boxers Preeti Pawar (above), Jaismine Lamboria (top right) and Sakshi Chaudhary won gold medals in Glasgow. PTI

NEW DELHI: "Go for the gold! This is the round," a charged-up India coach Santiago Nieva screamed into the ears of Priya Ghanghas, who was locked in a fierce contest against Canada's Marie-Bathoul Al-Ahmadieh. Before Priya took to the ring, Preeti Pawar (54kg), Jaismine Lamboria (57kg) and Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg) had all secured gold in high-voltage finals at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Saturday.

With 10 of the 14 Indian boxers making it to the final, the ring turned out to be a symbol of pride and cheer. One after another, Indians came to the ring and fought with hunger and drive for gold. India's national anthem just would not stop; the Tricolour kept fluttering high through the day.

Priya and Marie-Bathoul were a mismatch in height, but in the ring, little separated the two in the 60kg final. Marie-Bathoul made up for her shorter stature with aggression and power-packed punches. Priya was not the one to be rattled as she kept coming back with solid blows. The exchanges were intense in the first round and Marie-Bathoul won 3-2. Priya bounced back, taking the second round 4-1, and came out swinging in the crucial third round, eventually winning by split verdict and claiming her maiden CWG gold.

Four of the five judges scored it 29-28 for Priya, showing how close the fight was. An emerging talent from Bhiwani, Priya won gold at the Asian Championships.

The gold spree started with Preeti in the morning. Preeti, the most consistent boxer in the Indian team in the last couple of years, has been fighting with purpose since her ouster at the Paris Olympics in the Round of 16. Preeti, who won the Asian Championships gold earlier this year, dominated all her bouts in Glasgow. She put up a clinical display in the final against Canada's Scarlett Savannah Delgado, winning 5-0 and securing the first gold for the boxing team.

It is the best result for Indian boxers at CWG, winning seven gold and three silver medals. In 2022, Indian boxers returned with 3 gold, 1 silver and 3 bronze.

After Preeti, it was the turn of World Championships bronze medallist Jaismine Lamboria (57kg) to take to the ring. She edged past Northern Ireland's Michaela Walsh 5-0 to win the second gold for India. The close first round saw Jaismine winning 3-2, scoring on the counter. She impressed all five judges in the second round as her crosses and jabs landed effectively. Walsh fought back well in the third round, but the Indian had done enough to clinch gold. This was Jaismine's second medal at the CWG.

In the evening, Sakshi got the better of England's Ruby White in the 51kg final. Sakshi, the two-time world youth champion, came into the spotlight with a stellar win against two-time world champion Nikhat Zareen in the selection trials. With the Asian Games around the corner, she had a lot to prove. Sakshi did not disappoint, beating Ruby White 5-0.

Next came Arundhati Choudhary (70kg) to face England's Chantelle Reid, a 2025 World Championships bronze medallist. Reid was more attacking in the first round, but Arundhati stepped up brilliantly in the next two rounds, throwing good combination punches from close range. Arundhati, known for her flamboyant style, let her hooks and uppercuts do the talking. It was a truly memorable win for Arundhati, who is coming off a wrist injury that required surgery last year. She beat defending champion Rosie Eccles in the semis for two back-to-back big wins.

Lovlina loses

Tokyo Olympics bronze medallist Lovlina Borgohain, however, lost her 75kg final to Emma-Sue Greentree of Australia, a two-time World Championships medallist. Lovlina lost the first round but bounced back by taking the second. Greentree, however, took complete control in the third round to win gold with a 4-1 verdict.

Among the men, Sachin Siwach (60kg) beat Tryagain Morning Ndevelo of Namibia in a dramatic finish. The tall Ndevelo won the close first round 3-2, but Sachin fought back in the second. Sachin had a point deducted after a warning, putting him at a disadvantage. In the closing stages of the third round, Sachin struck a powerful punch that sent Ndevelo to the canvas, drawing a count from the referee. That proved crucial.

Later, Ankush added the 80kg gold, edging Dimeji Shittu of England 4-1.

Jadumani Singh settled for silver after losing to Australia's Jye Dixon in 55kg. Though Dixon won 5-0, the contest was much closer than what the score suggests. The first round itself was close, and Dixon prevailed 3-2.

In the last bout, Narender Berwal (+90kg) lost to England's Damar Thomas by a 0-5 verdict.

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Unnati's bronze medal lifts judo haul at CWG

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India's Unnati Sharma (in white) won bronze on Saturday. PTI

NEW DELHI: After a historic high that saw two gold medals and a silver on Friday, Indian judokas were brought back to earth on the penultimate day of the Glasgow Commonwealth Games on Saturday, taking a solitary bronze after three of the judokas stumbled on the final step before a medal.

Unnati Sharma (-63kg) was India's lone judo medallist of the day, beating South Africa's Skye Knoester by ippon in the bronze playoff. She wrapped up the contest in a minute and 7 seconds with the bout-stopping manoeuvre. She opened her campaign with a dominant Round of 16 victory over Eswatini's Lamulela Magagula, sealing the contest by ippon in one minute and 39 seconds after scoring two successive waza-ari.

She then edged past New Zealand's Qona Christie in the quarter-final, prevailing by waza-ari after also registering a yuko to book her place in the last four. In the last-four stage, Unnati went down by ippon to Australia's Saya Middleton, the eventual silver medallist, in the semis to drop into the bronze playoff.

This was India's fourth judo medal at this Games after Asmita Dey (gold), Harsh Singh (gold) and Yamini Mourya (silver) had medalled on Friday.

However, there was disappointment for Takhellambam Inunganbi (women's -70kg) and Karanjit Singh Maan (men's -90kg), who lost in repechage.

Inunganbi, who won bronze at the Asian Championships in Ordos City, China in April to end India's 13-year medal drought at the continental event, was billed as a medal hope but lost her opening quarter-final to Canada's Charlie Thibault in three minutes and 23 seconds after conceding a yuko earlier in the contest. She faced England's Jemima Yeats-Brown in the repechage but lost by ippon in 68 seconds.

Karanjit lost the men's -90kg last-eight clash to Canada's Guillaume Gaulin, conceding defeat by ippon after defeating New Zealand's Elliott Connolly by ippon in three minutes and 29 seconds. He later lost in repechage to local Scott Cusack.

Harsh Tokas narrowly missed out on the men's -81kg bronze, losing to Australia's Keishin Ochi by ippon. The contest began cautiously, with both judokas receiving a Shido (penalty) for passivity within the opening 18 seconds.

Tokas picked up a second Shido midway through the match. With 43 seconds remaining, Ochi seized his opportunity, executing a quick throw.

South Delhi Superstarz's Anshuman Hooda picked up 5/24. DPL

Hooda snaps up 5 as Superstarz win

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NEW DELHI: Anshuman Hooda bowled brilliantly to set up victory as South Delhi Superstarz chased down a competitive total to defeat East Delhi Riders by four wickets in the second match of the Delhi Premier League 2026 at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Saturday.

Hooda's brilliant spell of 5/24 in 3.1 overs was a major factor in South Delhi Superstarz's limiting East Delhi Riders to 165 all out in 18.1 overs after electing to bowl.

Deepak Punia, Simarjeet Singh, Suryansh Raina, Mayank Rawat and Dhruv Kaushik were all removed by the right-arm pacer in a final burst that changed the course of the match.

Earlier, Arpit Rana led the Riders' batting with a scorching 66 off 39 balls, hitting three sixes and six fours. Anmol Sharma, who top-scored with 64 off just 36 balls, hitting eight boundaries and two sixes, which helped Superstarz overcome an early setback.

Captain Ayush Badoni provided momentum with a 23-run cameo off just 11 deliveries, while Pranav Pant added a quickfire 24. Karan Garg maintained his composure with an undefeated 27 off 28 balls.

Although East Delhi Riders fought back through Ashish Meena (2/24) and Rounak Waghela (2/54), Karan Garg held his nerve with an unbeaten 27. South Delhi finished with 169/6 in 18.1 overs, sealing victory with 11 balls to spare.

In the second match of the day, West Delhi Lions defeated New Delhi Tigers by 19 runs in an exciting encounter.

HT

Tanvi enters final in Taipei, Unnati loses

TAIPEI CITY: Indian shuttler Tanvi Sharma stayed on course for her first BWF World Tour title, defeating Chinese Taipei's Huang Yu-Hsun 21-17, 21-11 to enter the women's singles final of the Taipei Open here.

Indians seal all singles semis spots

NEW DELHI: India stamped its authority on the penultimate day of the Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships, with all 8 paddlers storming into the men's and women's singles semi-finals here on Saturday.

India drawn with Maldives, Pakistan

NEW DELHI: Defending champions India have been drawn with Maldives and Pakistan in Group B of the SAFF Championship 2026, following the draw conducted in Thimphu, Bhutan, on Saturday.

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GULVEER WINS 5,000M BRONZE AFTER CLAIMING 10,000M SILVER

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NEW DELHI: Gulveer Singh followed upon his 10000m silver with a clinical bronze in the 5000m to cap a memorable Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Saturday. The 28-year-old Armyman clocked 13 minutes, 24.95 seconds to become the first Indian to win two athletics medals in a single edition of CWG. The medal also made him only the second Indian to win the 5000m race in CWG, after Hari Chand's bronze in Edmonton 1978.

Running a supremely tactical race, Gulveer kept himself in the leading group for much of the race and pushed himself into the medal bracket with a perfectly-timed finishing kick in the final 200m. He was boxed in by the Kenyan duo of Mathew Kipchumba Kipsang and Cornelius Kemboi in the last lap, but broke free in the final straight.

He looked headed for a silver but Australian Ky Robinson (13:24.70), the 10000m winner, surged from fourth to second with a superb acceleration in the last 100m. Kipsang completed a wire-to-wire win in 13:23.61 minutes. Gulveer though pipped Cornelius Kemboi to the line.

Eighth at the end of the opening lap, Gulveer began his acceleration in the second to jump to the second spot behind Kipsang. He held firm till the end of the first 1000m. He dropped to fifth after the next 2000m and remained steady for the next kilometre.

Gulveer began to come up the final 1,000m, going past Robinson to take the third spot. Unflustered by the mounting pressure, Gulveer kept his position and was in with a chance to claim silver before Robinson came up in the final 100m. "Every race is different, so I don't want to think too much about what has already happened. Winning 10,000m silver is satisfying and gives me confidence, but once I step onto the track for the 5,000m, it's a completely new race. I'll recover well, prepare with my coach, and focus on executing the race the best I can," he had said before the race.

After trying times, Neeraj accepts silver on comeback

Plagued by injuries over last two years, the javelin star on reset still managed a podium in Glasgow

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MUMBAI: There's a certain peculiarity in listening to Neeraj Chopra speak as a silver medallist at a major multi-sport event. He did so for a second straight time at the 2026 Commonwealth Games, after the 2024 Paris Olympics.

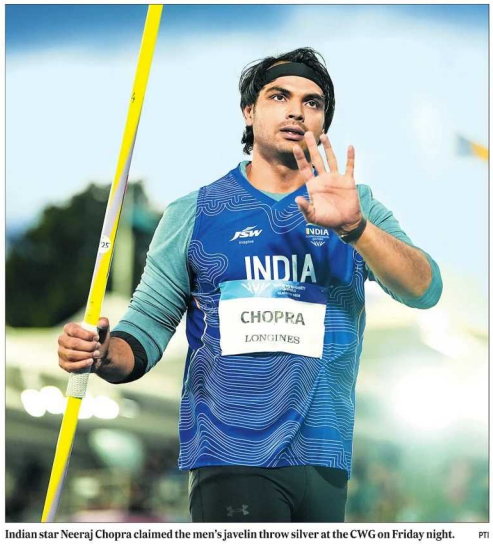
Indians, athletes as well as fans, celebrate medals of any colour in once-in-four-years Games, but it's different when it comes to the country's modern-day gold standard athlete.

In Paris, where the defending Olympic champion took silver, Chopra's tone for most part of his media interaction carried more frustration of his body not being fit enough to dig out that one mammoth throw than jubilation of being a rare Indian sportsperson to call himself a multiple Olympic medallist.

On Friday night in Glasgow after the javelin final, where the 2018 CWG champion returned to the podium after sitting out of the previous edition and battling a couple of injury-hampered seasons, Chopra kept saying on multiple occasions — "*yeh bhi theek hai* (this too is just fine)".

In a quality field (certainly more than many events at this CWG from an India point of view) where five men had a personal best of 90m-plus and in testing windy conditions, Chopra finished second with a season's best of 85.83m off his second attempt.

The 28-year-old's first few sentences while speaking to the media had rich words for Yashvir Singh, his bronze medallist compatriot whose personal best 85.41m off his last attempt ensured a first double podium finish for India in javelin at CWG.



Indian star Neeraj Chopra claimed the men's javelin throw silver at the CWG on Friday night. PTI

He then credited Sri Lanka's Rumesh Tharanga, 23, for his only legal throw, the defining one at 89.75m, which set him apart from the rest and added another feather to the budding pacer turned season's leading thrower's sensational rise.

As for himself, well, "*theek hai*". "In such competitions, I always try to get the Indian national anthem played," Chopra told the media in Glasgow. "*Par, yeh bhi theek hai.* I have given my season best."

Chopra's season began only in June, at the Doha Diamond League where he finished fourth with 85.69m. It was his first competitive outing after signing off eighth at the Tokyo World Championships as the defending champion last September.

Throughout last season, Chopra, who spoke about persistent groin trouble in Paris, continued to battle physical issues. He had the much-craved 90m throw in the bag but his celebrated consistency went somewhat missing. He parted ways with Jan Zelezny and went back to childhood coach Jai Choudhary.

Resets of such kind demand time. Comebacks from injuries and considerable time off can demand patience.

Only a few top-notch athletes across sport can turn up after months of inaction or sub-par performances and turn it on when it matters on the big stage. Think Novak Djokovic. Or, PV Sindhu in her pomp.

Pakistan's Olympic champion Arshad Nadeem had competed in just one event in a year, a below 80m effort 15 days before CWG, coming to Glasgow. He fizzled out from the final's first set of throws after a 78.63m. It would thus have been understandable if that was the case with Chopra, more so after his Doha and CWG qualification (79.61m in tougher conditions) outings.

Chopra, though, is top-notch, technically too. No matter him being "not as fit as before", as he put it, and only "getting back to rhythm gradually". "The comeback is going okay," Chopra said. "If you're 100% fit, you have the fighting spirit, and that feeling that you can do anything. If you're returning from an injury, you have to be watchful. Today I had that fear in my mind, that I shouldn't overdo anything."

Chopra's best came off his second throw, for a brief lead. So did Tharanga's benchmark-setting and lone valid throw. The Indian responded with 81.29m and 80.73m before choosing to scratch the final two attempts. "Even I had just one throw that went well. I was hoping for a few more. I had a feeling I could throw more, but the javelin did not fly," Chopra said.

He said though the conditions were better than during qualifying, it was still cold, which he doesn't prefer. "Indian *khoon hai*," he chuckled.

Having an Indian alongside him among the medals made him happier, reminding him of the Guangzhou Asian Games. Yashvir was happy being in the company of his country's javelin pathbreaker. Until five throws, his best of 81.33m would not have been enough for that. Until, after some words by Chopra, the 24-year-old from Rajasthan produced his best ever 85.41m to leapfrog to bronze. "The biggest thing is," said Chopra of the Indian flavour on the podium, "if I'm not on the field or out injured, there are others behind me who can take care of things and throw well."

Like Chopra did on the day, a challenging comeback and conditions notwithstanding. "Gold is a different feeling altogether," he said. "*Par, yeh bhi theek hai.* It's good to be back on the podium after a while."

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RESULTS (INDIANS ONLY)

SACHIN SIWACH

ATHLETICS
Men's triple jump final
Praveen Chrithravel won silver; T Selva Prabhu won bronze
Women's 10,000m race walk final
Priyanka Goswami ended 4th
Ravina Gayakwad was disqualified
Men's 5,000m final
Gulveer Singh won bronze

BOWLS
Men's pairs, Group B
India lost to England via tiebreaker
Women's singles, Group C
Nayanmoni Saikia lost to Bridget Herselman (RSA) via tiebreaker

BOXING
Women's 54kg final
Preeti Pawar won gold
Women's 57kg final
Jaismine Lamboria won gold
Men's 55kg final
Jadumani Singh won silver
Women's 51kg final
Sakshi Chaudhary won gold
Women's 60kg final
Priya Ghanghas won gold
Women's 70kg final
Arundhati won gold
Women's 75kg final
Lovlina Borgohain won silver
Men's 80kg final
Ankush Panghal won gold
Men's 60kg final
Sachin Siwach won gold
Men's 90+kg final
Narender Berwal won silver

JUDO
Women's 63kg
Unnati Sharma won bronze
Women's 70kg
Takhellambam Inunganbi lost in repechage
Men's 90kg
Karanjit Singh Maan lost in repechage
Men's 81kg
Harsh Tokas lost bronze playoff

PARA ATHLETICS
Men's shot put F57 final
Soman Rana won gold
Shubham Juyal won silver
Men's 1,500m T54 final
Ramesh Shanmugam ended 7th

TRACK CYCLING
Men's sprint
David Beckham, Ronaldo Singh, Rojit Singh failed to qualify for last 16
Men's 10km scratch race
Harshveer Singh Sekhon and Dinesh Kumar did not finish
Men's elimination race final
Harshveer Singh Sekhon ended 21st

Rana, Juyal clinch 1-2 in para shot put

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MUMBAI: There's been something about Indian para athletes and double podium finishes at the Commonwealth Games.

Sharmila Dhankar and Shilpa Shyla began the trend by capturing gold and bronze, respectively, in the women's shot put F57 category. Then, Dilip Gavit and Mohammed Basil produced a memorable 1-2 finish in the men's 100m T47 event.

Soman Rana and Shubham Juyal added to it on the final day of para athletics on Saturday, winning gold and silver in the men's shot put F57 category.

It capped off a fine campaign in Glasgow for India's para athletes, and the para contingent as a whole. It added seven medals to the overall tally, the best ever performance by an Indian para contingent at the CWG. Apart from one bronze from para powerlifting, six of those came from athletics, including three gold. Each of those had another Indian on the podium.

On Friday evening, it was Rana and Juyal with the double act. In the 10-man shot put final that had them head and shoulders above the rest (after Rana's PB of 15.17m and Juyal's 14.86m, the next best was Cameron's Cedric Azamdzi with 12.70m), the Indian duo living up to their billing.

Rana took gold with an effort of 13.40m off his second attempt, while Juyal was next best at 13.28m from his final attempt. Azamdzi took bronze with 12.57m.

The triumph adds another chapter to the remarkable journey of 43-year-old Armyman Rana. His father a farmer and mother a housewife, Rana joined the Gorkha Rifles as a sepoy in 2001, and was part of his unit's boxing team.

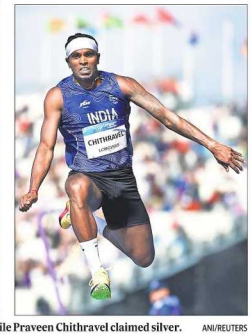
Five years later, while serving in the line of control in Jammu and Kashmir, he was badly injured in a mine blast, which resulted in an amputation below the knee. Transferred to the Army's Artificial Limb Centre in Pune, Rana never gave up on his sporting ambitions. He took up para athletics and joined the Army Paralympic Node in 2017.

He won gold at the Indian Open Para Athletics in 2023, and silver at the Asian Para Games held in Hangzhou. The Paralympics have been more testing — he came fourth in Tokyo in 2021 and 5th in Paris in 2024 — but this CWG gold adds a missing medal from his cabinet.

Juyal, the 30-year-old from Roorkee, took trains at Pune's Army Paralympic Node. His father retiring as a Naib Subedar, the son too cleared the written exam for the Army Cadet College entry scheme in 2022. A serious motorcycle accident while heading for his SSB interview, however, turned his life.

Going through rehab in Pune, Juyal was given the option to pursue either a vocational diploma course or para sports. He picked the latter, and hasn't looked back since. After winning gold at the Indian Open Para Athletics Grand Prix earlier this year, this is his first major international medal.

Soman Rana (R) and Shubham Juyal finished 1-2 in Glasgow. GETTY



Decathlete Tejaswin Shankar (L) won bronze while Praveen Chithravel claimed silver. ANI/REUTERS

How Tejaswin fought pain to rewrite history

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NEW DELHI: Four days after he cut a sorry, sobbing figure on being forced out of the high jump final due to an injury flare-up, Tejaswin Shankar was a picture of triumph and resilience at Glasgow's Scotstoun Stadium.

The 27-year-old, the only Indian to cross 8000 points in decathlon, willed himself to a first ever CWG medal for India in the combined discipline with bronze late on Friday night.

Tejaswin logged 7976 points after two days of gruelling competition to finish behind Grenada's Lindon Victor (8096) and Canada's Damian Warner (8036). Victor, the 2024 Paris Olympics bronze medalist, won his third straight CWG gold while Warner, the 2021 Tokyo Olympics champion and multiple Worlds medallist, took silver.

"I have been watching their videos since the day I decided to try decathlon. To share the podium with them feels great," Tejaswin told reporters. "I had a bronze in high jump in the previous edition and now one in decathlon. I don't know how many people have been able to do that."

It was a remarkable turnaround for Tejaswin who found himself sucked into a negative spiral after his patellar tendinopathy resurfaced. Emotional help came from long jumper Murali Sreeshankar, who missed the Paris Olympics following a patellar tendon rupture in his left knee, an injury that put him out of action for over a year and very nearly ended his career. "I was really down the day that injury happened. But the next day, I had a chat with Sree who is coming off a similar injury. He told me to assess it after 100m," Tejaswin said.

The first of the 10 events, 100m is followed by long jump, shot put, high jump and 400m on Day 1. Long jump and high jump put a significant load on the take-off knee, which meant pain tolerance and management became critical. "I was told by (team doctor) Dr. Dinshaw Pardiwalla that there was no chance that I would rupture my tendon. Once I knew that, it all came down to my pain threshold. The knee held up after the 100, so I took it event by event. I was fine after long jump and high jump which put the most stress on the knee. Once I managed that, I knew I'll finish the event."

Strength and conditioning expert Wayne Lombard helped as well. "With these patellar tendonitis or acute flare-ups, you needed quite a bit of time for it to settle down, so the doctor put him on anti-inflammatories. Once I had a quiet knee, then we could see we are making progress," Lombard told HT from Glasgow. "By a quiet knee I mean we needed the pain and the inflammation to settle." Besides anti-inflammatory drugs, Lombard outsourced a hyperbaric chamber, red light therapy, and Pulsed Electromagnetic Field (PEMF) therapy to expedite recovery.

Then came isometric muscle actions that involved putting gentle pressure on the knee. The process continued on the second day of injury — day before competition — as Lombard got Tejaswin into the actual jump positions, holding the contractions. "That gave him confidence in the take-off position. Once he knew the knee will hold up and he's not going to experience as much discomfort, he was good to go."

Tejaswin ensured the hard work didn't go in vain. A 7.82m long jump and a 2.15m high jump were best in the field as he ended Day 1 second with 4339 points. Day 2 began with him doing 110m hurdles in 14.41secs — second fastest overall — and maintained a consistent tempo to finish with a medal.

Silver for Praveen

In men's triple jump, India had two men on the podium for the second edition in a row with modest efforts. Praveen Chithravel, fourth in 2022 with 16.89m and with a national record of 17.37m, cleared 16.58m for silver. T Selva Prabhu was third with a best of 16.52m. Jamaica's Jordan Scott won with 16.72m.

In women's 10,000m race walk, Priyanka Goswami came fourth clocking 45:53.93. Ravina Gayakwad was disqualified after three red cards for 'running'.

medalstally

	COUNTRY				
1	AUS	61	37	50	148
2	ENG	25	40	34	99
3	CAN	18	18	21	57
4	IND	13	17	9	39
5	SCO	12	8	17	37
6	NGR	10	6	5	21
7	WAL	8	10	12	30
8	NZL	8	10	9	27
9	MAS	8	3	3	14
10	RSA	7	10	10	27

TILL MIDNIGHT

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

TRACK CYCLING
- **Men's 40km points race qualifying:** Harshveer Singh Sekhon and Dinesh Kumar (2:09pm)
- **Men's 1,000m time trial final:** Ronaldo Singh (3:51pm)

PARA TRACK CYCLING
- **Women's C4-C5 1,000m time trial final:** Lisha Das (8:40pm)

JUDO
- **Women's 78kg** Ishroop Narang (2:30pm)
- **Men's 100kg** Avtar Singh (2:30pm)
- **Men's +100kg** Yash Ghangas (2:30pm)

CLOSING CEREMONY
1:30AM (MONDAY)

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